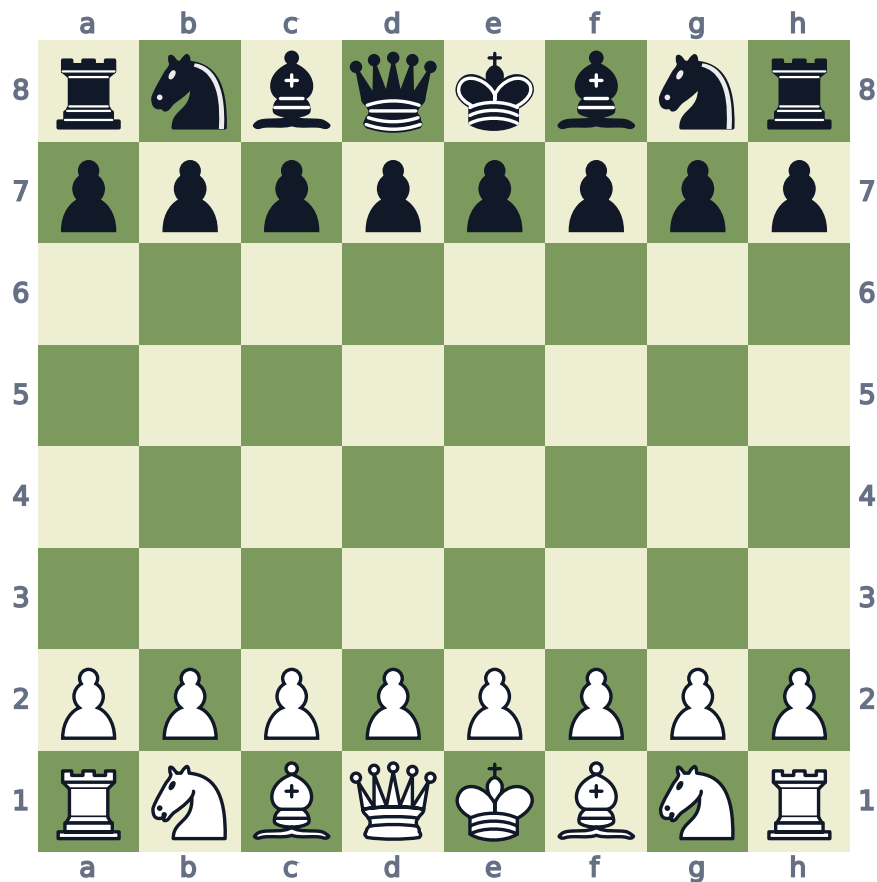


Opening-to-Middlegame Transitions

Plan maps for the fifty most useful opening families



Move beyond memorization by connecting every opening to its pawn breaks, piece placements, tactical motifs, common mistakes, and first middlegame decision.

50 learning units | explanations | board laboratories | review system

ORIENTATION

What this course will change

COURSE PROMISE

Move beyond memorization by connecting every opening to its pawn breaks, piece placements, tactical motifs, common mistakes, and first middlegame decision.

YOU WILL LEARN TO

- Recognize the opening's structural identity
- Recall plans for both sides
- Find the thematic pawn break
- Know when the opening phase is truly over

HOW TO USE THE COURSE

- Study one learning unit at a time. Say the rule in your own words before continuing.
- At each diagram, hide the model answer. Write candidates and the opponent's best reply.
- Use the rule during a slow game, then record whether it actually changed a decision.
- Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Retrieval matters more than rereading.

SCOPE

This course contains 50 integrated learning units. Principles guide attention, but tactics and exact calculation always decide the move.

CORE METHOD

The decision protocol

USE THIS EVERY TIME

A reliable process is more valuable than a brilliant idea used occasionally. Practice the sequence until it becomes automatic under clock pressure.

1**Name the pawn structure.****2****Identify each side's best and worst pieces.****3****Locate thematic breaks.****4****Predict the next plan before revealing it.****5****Store the position as a pattern, not a string of moves.****STOPPING RULE**

Choose when one candidate is sufficiently verified for the clock situation. Before moving, inspect the position once from the opponent's perspective.

COURSE MAP

The opening families

OPEN GAMES

8 transition maps

SEMI-OPEN GAMES

3 transition maps

SICILIAN DEFENSE

13 transition maps

HYPERMODERN DEFENSES

3 transition maps

QUEEN'S PAWN OPENINGS

5 transition maps

INDIAN DEFENSES

6 transition maps

FLANK AND INDIAN SYSTEMS

1 transition maps

FLANK OPENINGS

4 transition maps

QUEEN'S PAWN SYSTEMS

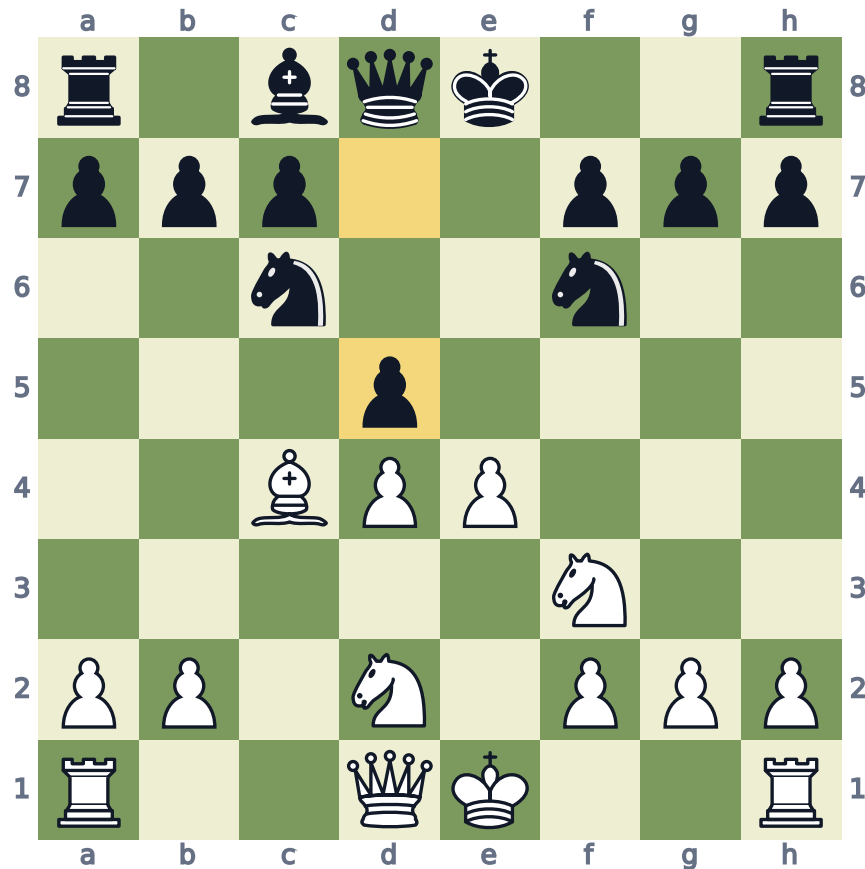
7 transition maps

TRANSITION MAP 01 | C50-C54

Italian Game

IDENTITY

Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+ 7. Bd2 Bxd2+ 8. Nbx d2 d5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 01

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it.

BLACK'S PLAN

Meet d4 in the center, finish development, and avoid passive defense around f7.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Pressure on f7, a central fork on e5, and pins on the e-file after castling.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Attacking f7 repeatedly while the king remains in the center.

MEMORY CUE

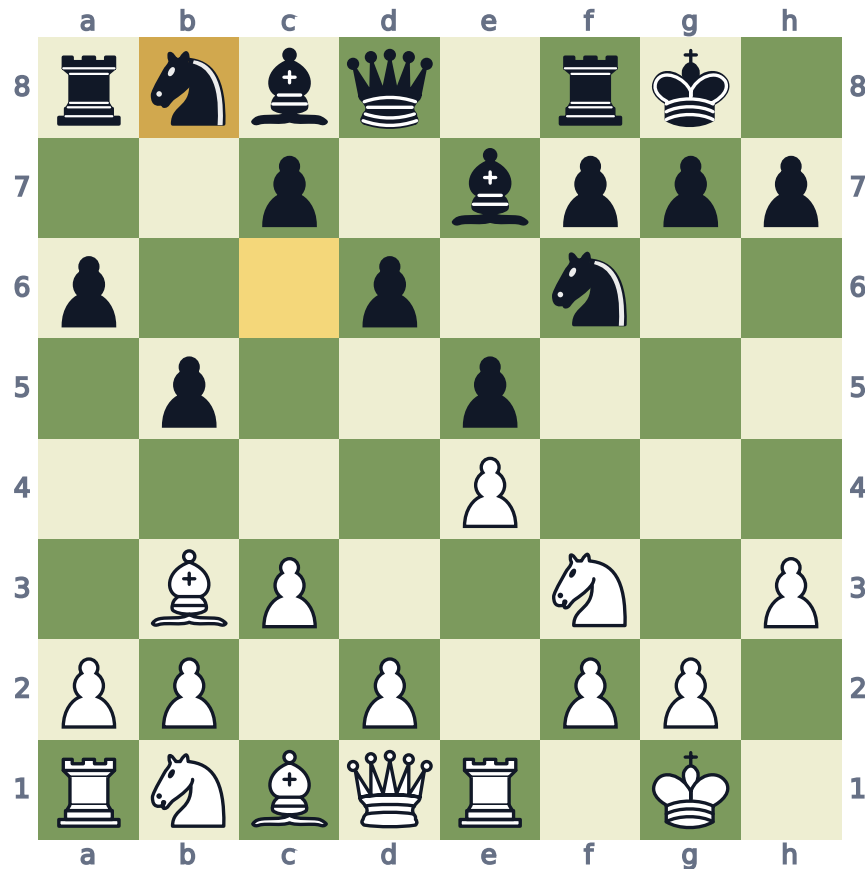
Develop, build d4, castle, then attack.

TRANSITION MAP 02 | C60-C99

Ruy Lopez

IDENTITY

Long-term pressure on e5 created by pinning the c6-knight.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 02

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Prepare d4 with c3, preserve the light bishop, and improve pieces before opening the center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Gain space with ...b5, defend e5, and reorganize the queenside knight toward d7.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White wants d4; Black often seeks ...d5 after enough preparation.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The e5 pawn can become loose when its knight defender is pinned or diverted.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Taking c6 and e5 automatically without checking whether ...Qd4 or ...Qf6 regains the pawn.

MEMORY CUE

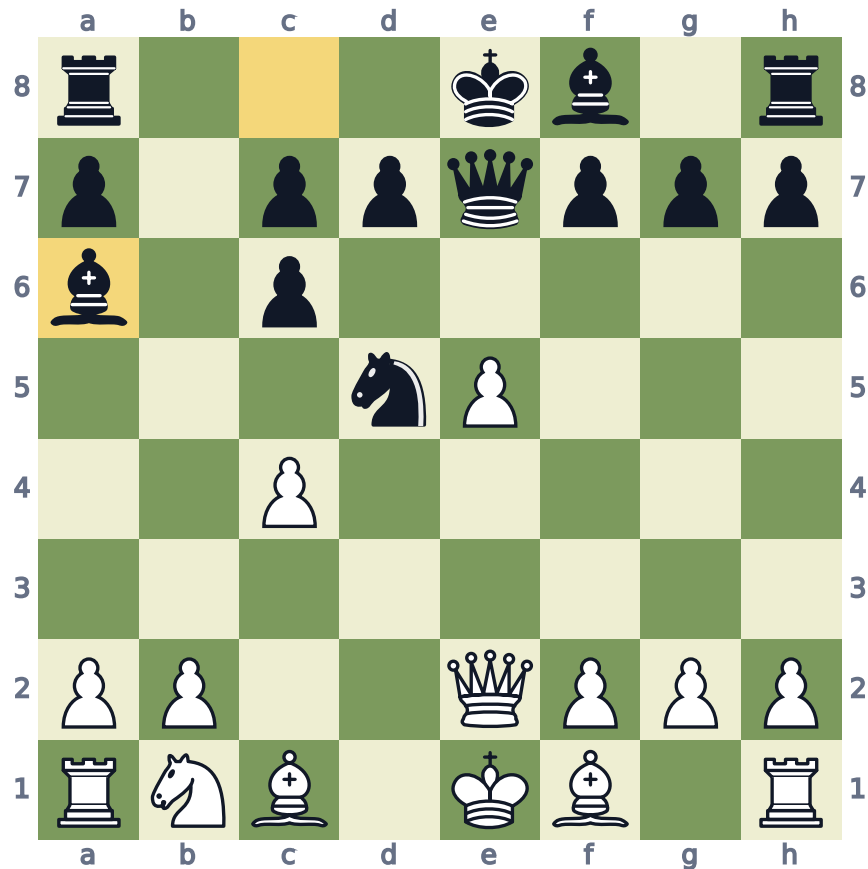
Pressure first, center second, tactics only when ready.

TRANSITION MAP 03 | C44-C45

Scotch Game

IDENTITY

White opens the center immediately and asks Black's pieces concrete questions.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 exd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2 Nd5 8. c4 Ba6

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 03

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the space from e5, develop rapidly, and target the altered queenside pawns.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge e5, use open files and the bishop pair, and avoid falling behind in development.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...d6 or ...d5 challenges White's advanced e-pawn.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A queen check on the e-file and pressure on e5 can gain time against White's queen.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Trading in the center and then making extra queen moves while pieces remain home.

MEMORY CUE

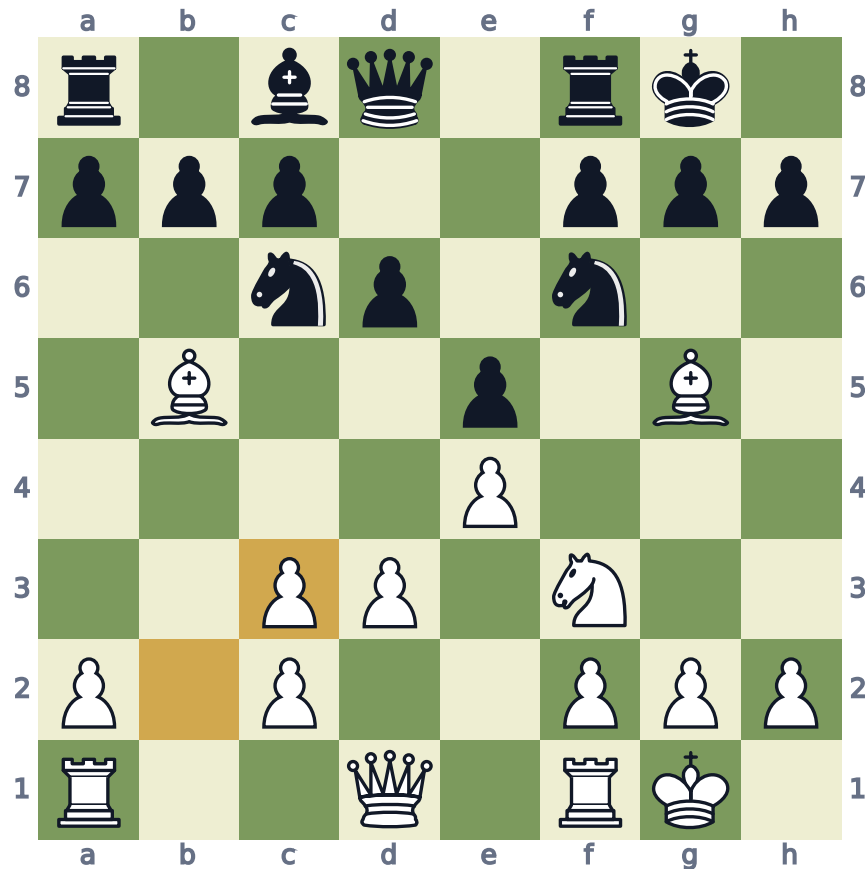
Open center means every tempo matters.

TRANSITION MAP 04 | C47-C49

Four Knights Game

IDENTITY

Natural development produces a sound, balanced center with rich middlegames.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bb5 Bb4 5. O-O O-O 6. d3 d6 7. Bg5 Bxc3 8. bxc3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 04

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Castle, choose d4 or a kingside buildup, and use the bishop pin to shape the center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Match development, decide when to exchange on c3, and strike with ...d5 when possible.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

The d-pawn break by either side determines whether the game stays quiet.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Pins on c3 and f6 can make an apparently defended e-pawn tactically vulnerable.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Assuming symmetry means there are no tactics after one side pins first.

MEMORY CUE

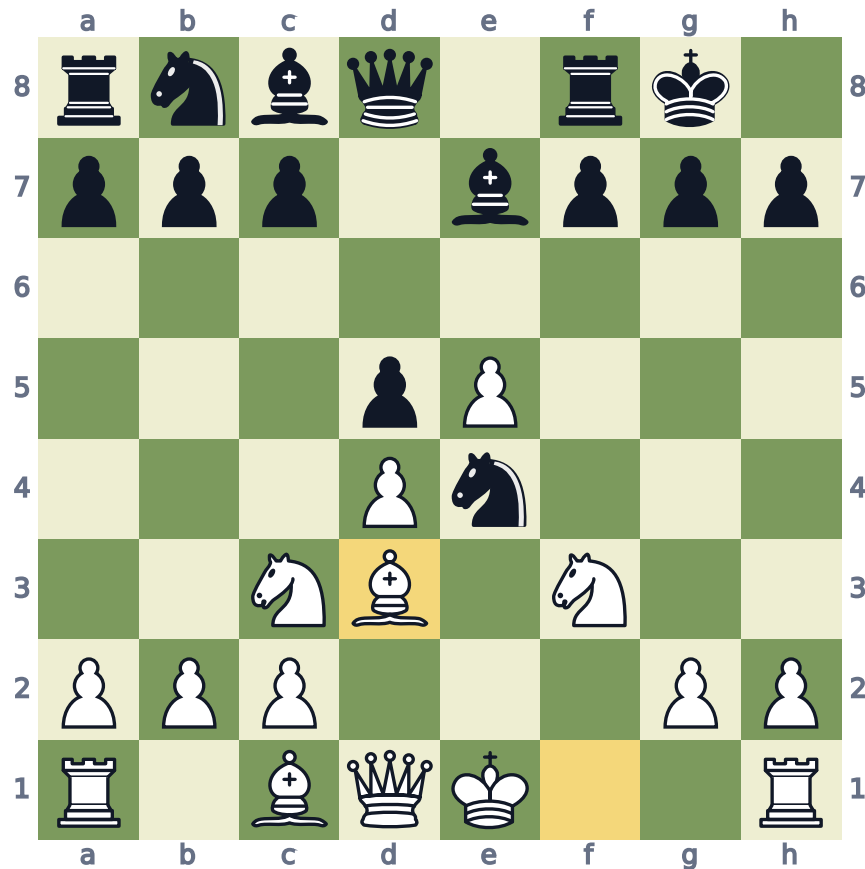
Complete development, then break symmetry.

TRANSITION MAP 05 | C25-C29

Vienna Game

IDENTITY

Flexible development with the option of a fast f-pawn attack.



1. e4 e5 2. Nc3 Nf6 3. f4 d5 4. fxe5 Nxe4 5. Nf3 Be7 6. d4 O-O 7. Bd3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 05

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Support e4, use f4 to challenge e5, and open lines only with pieces ready.

BLACK'S PLAN

Counter in the center with ...d5 and make White prove the kingside expansion is safe.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's f4 is the signature break; Black's ...d5 is the principled reply.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The e4-knight can be attacked, but tactical exchanges on c3 and e5 must be calculated first.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing f4, f5, and g4 without developing or checking the center.

MEMORY CUE

Flank pressure works because the center is supported.

King's Gambit

White offers a pawn to pull Black's e-pawn away and accelerate an attack.



15

TRANSITION MAP 06

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop with tempo, recover control of the center, and open files toward the black king.

BLACK'S PLAN

Keep the extra pawn only when safe, counter in the center, and return material to finish development.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's d4 restores central control; Black's ...d5 challenges the attacking setup.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Checks on h5 and sacrifices on f7 appear when Black's king and kingside pawns are stretched.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Trying to win the f4-pawn back immediately instead of completing development.

MEMORY CUE

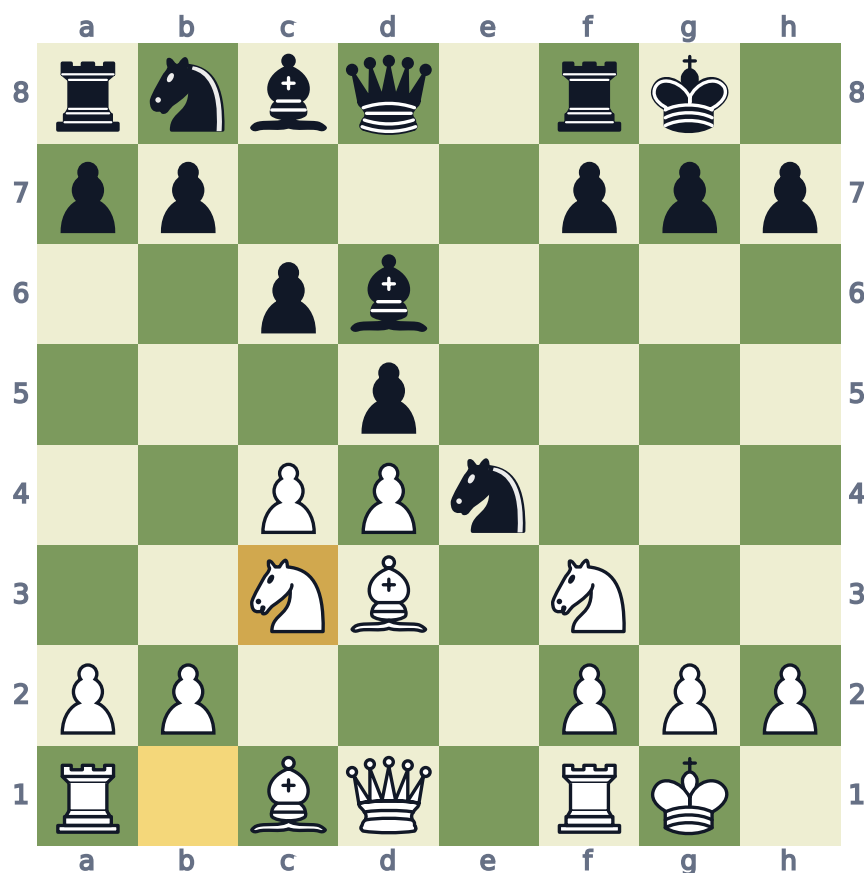
The pawn is an investment in time, not a debt.

TRANSITION MAP 07 | C42-C43

Petrov Defense

IDENTITY

Black mirrors the attack on e4 and aims for active equality rather than passive defense.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Nxe5 d6 4. Nf3 Nxe4 5. d4 d5 6. Bd3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. c4 c6 9. Nc3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 07

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the lead in space, challenge the e4-knight, and create an isolated-pawn or open-center target.

BLACK'S PLAN

Return the pawn correctly, centralize, and use the symmetrical structure without drifting.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

c4 challenges Black's d5 anchor; ...c6 reinforces or prepares a later queenside expansion.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

After Nx e5, Black must play ...d6 before taking e4; immediate copying loses material.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Copying Nx e4 before driving White's knight from e5.

MEMORY CUE

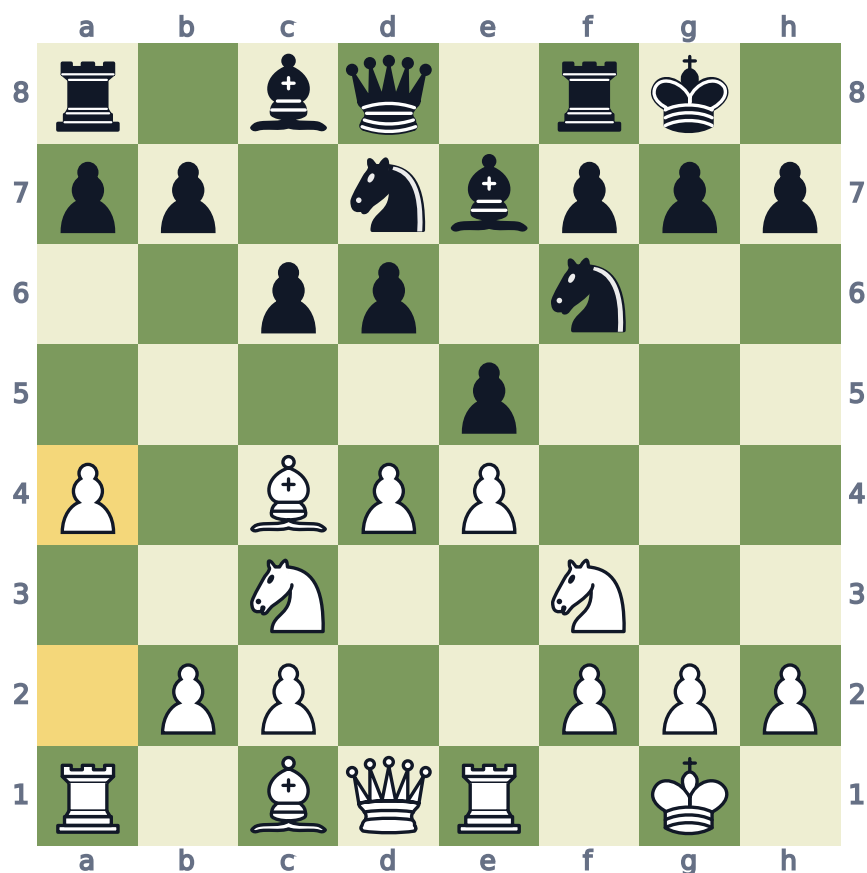
Challenge, chase, recover - in that order.

TRANSITION MAP 08 | C41

Philidor Defense

IDENTITY

A compact e5-d6 chain that values solidity and controlled expansion.



1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1 c6 8. a4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 08

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use space, develop smoothly, and prevent Black's freeing breaks from arriving comfortably.

BLACK'S PLAN

Finish development, support e5, and prepare ...c6 with ...Qc7 or the freeing ...d5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black needs ...d5 or sometimes ...c6 and ...b5 to avoid permanent congestion.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The e-file becomes dangerous if Black delays castling while e5 is pinned.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing ...Nbd7, ...Be7, and ...O-O without planning a freeing break.

MEMORY CUE

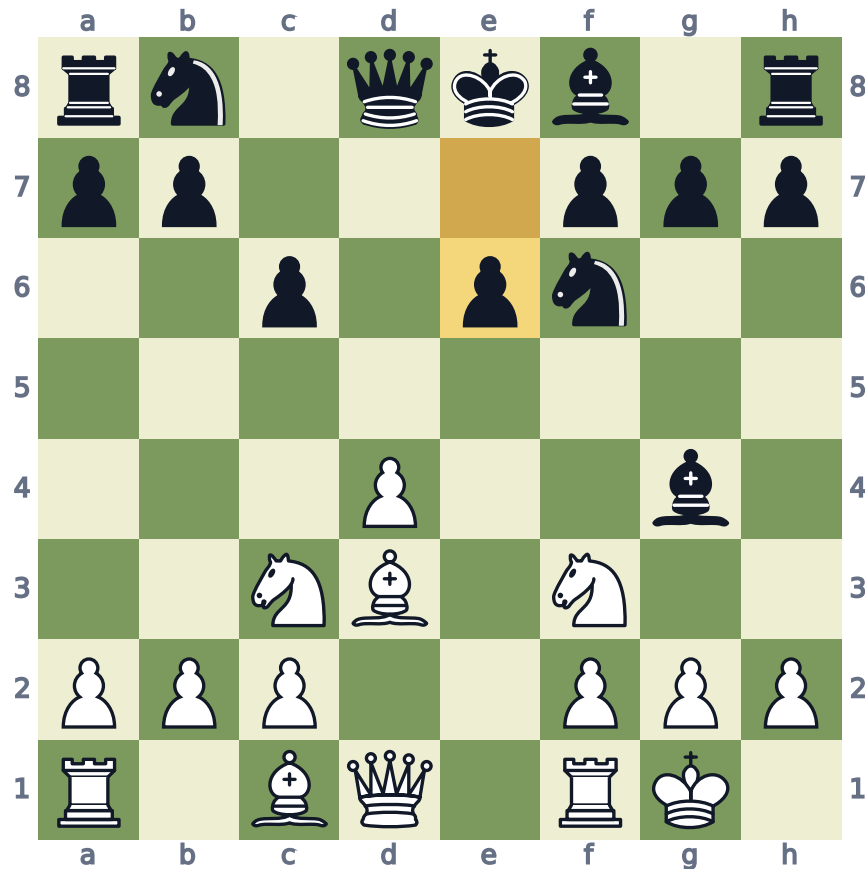
Solid first, free the position second.

TRANSITION MAP 09 | B01

Scandinavian Defense

IDENTITY

Black challenges e4 on move one and accepts queen tempi for a clear structure.



1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bd3 Bg4 7. O-O e6

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 09

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop with tempo, occupy the center, and use the space lead before it disappears.

BLACK'S PLAN

Place the queen safely, build a light-square structure, and finish development without more lost tempi.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...c5 challenges d4; White may use d5 if development supports the advance.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Pins on f3 and pressure on d4 can compensate for Black's early queen retreat.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Chasing the queen with pawns that weaken White's own position.

MEMORY CUE

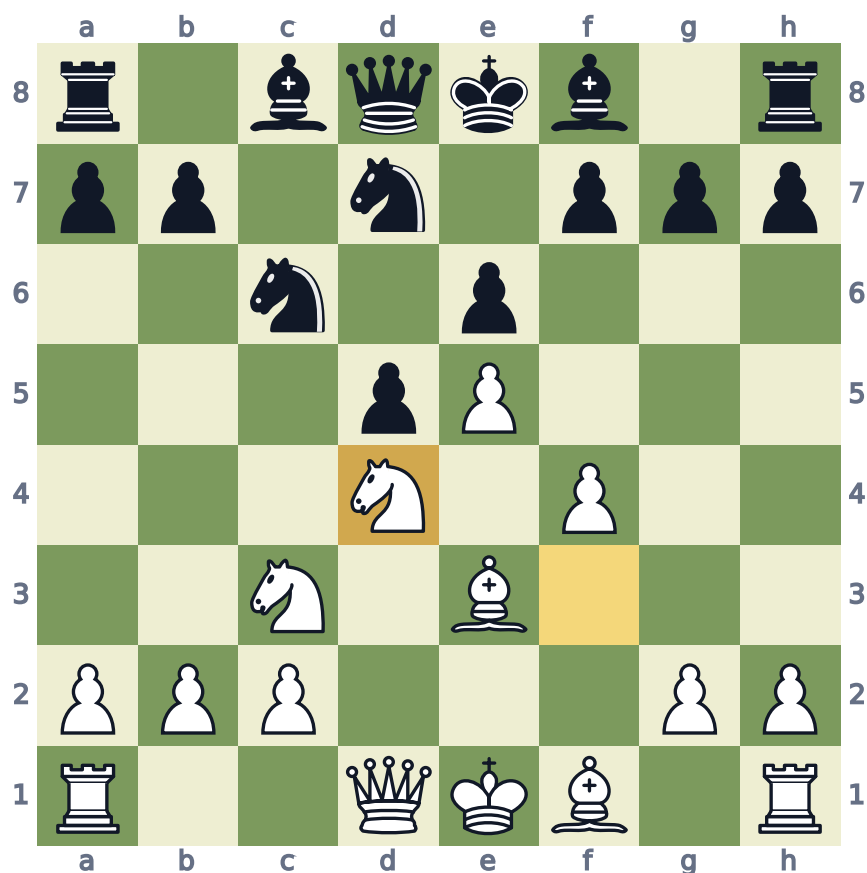
Take the free development, not a pawn-chasing detour.

TRANSITION MAP 10 | C00-C19

French Defense

IDENTITY

A locked center creates a battle between White's space and Black's pawn breaks.



1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. f4 c5 6. Nf3 Nc6 7. Be3 cxd4 8. Nxd4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 10

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Support e5, develop the queenside, and attack where the pawn chain points.

BLACK'S PLAN

Attack d4 with ...c5, challenge e5 with ...f6, and activate the c8-bishop deliberately.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 is essential; ...f6 is the second lever against White's center.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

When the center opens, d4 and e5 can become tactical targets rather than permanent strengths.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For Black, accepting a cramped position without striking at d4; for White, attacking before development.

MEMORY CUE

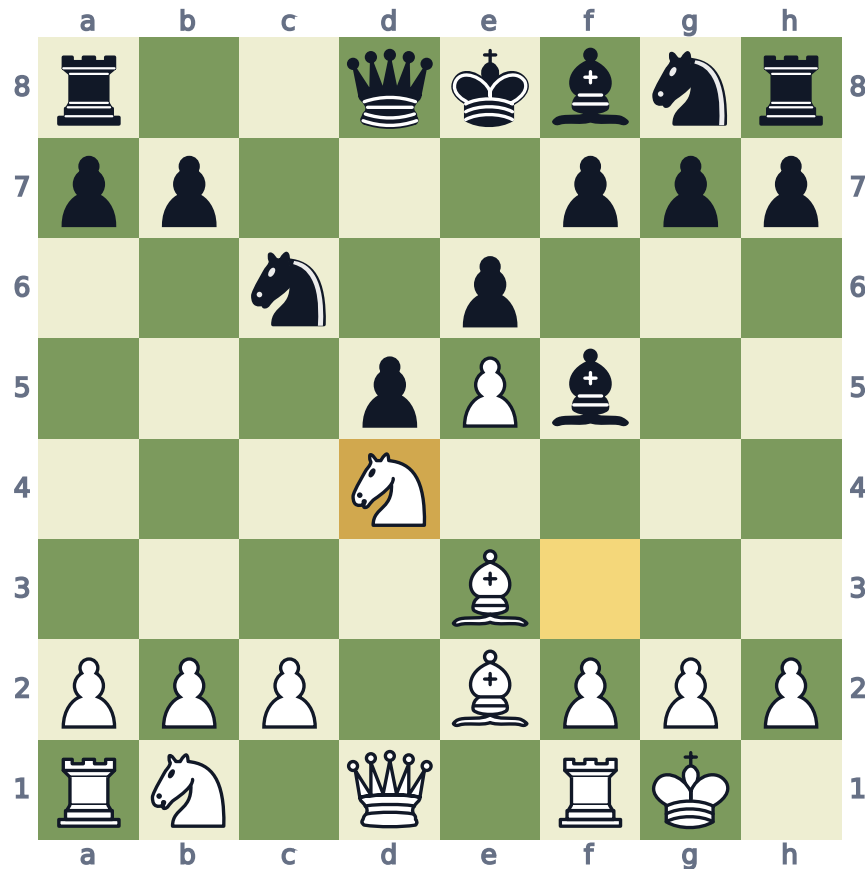
Pawn chains point toward the wing of attack.

TRANSITION MAP 11 | B10-B19

Caro-Kann Defense

IDENTITY

Black builds a sound center while keeping the light bishop outside the pawn chain.



1. e4 c6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 Bf5 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 c5 6. O-O Nc6 7. Be3 cxd4 8. Nxd4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 11

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use space, develop without blocking the center, and respond accurately to ...c5.

BLACK'S PLAN

Complete development, challenge d4, and avoid allowing e5 to become untouchable.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 is the main equalizing lever; ...f6 may attack e5 later.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The f5-bishop can be chased, but every pawn push leaves squares behind.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Spending many tempi trapping the bishop while Black breaks open the center.

MEMORY CUE

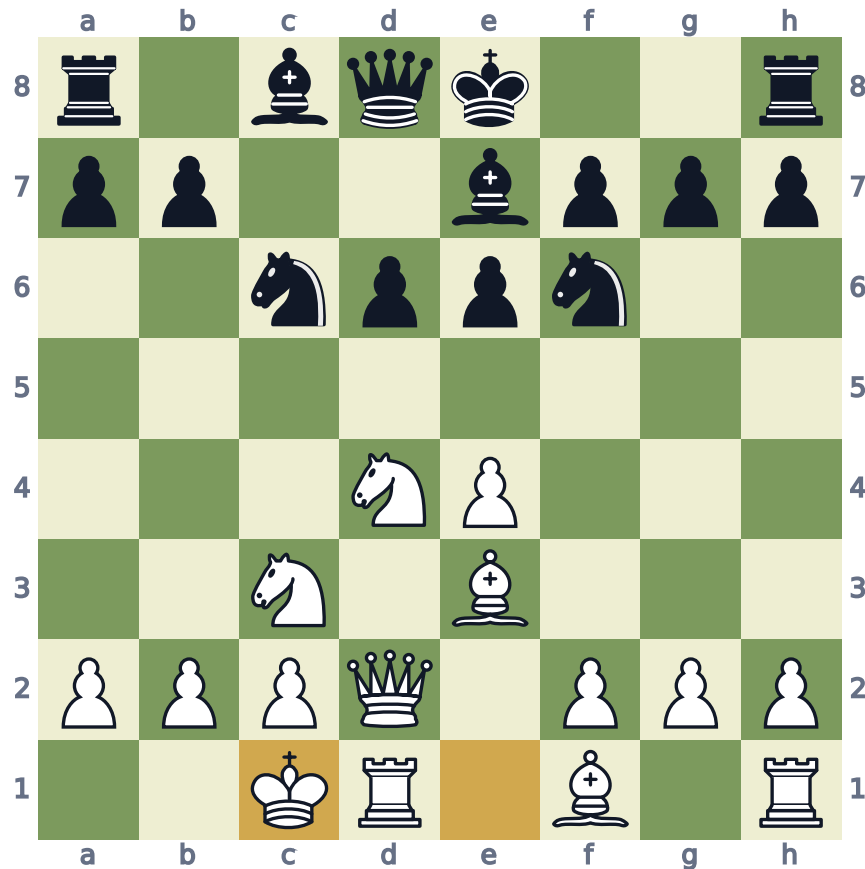
Bishop out, center challenged, structure sound.

TRANSITION MAP 12 | B20-B99

Open Sicilian

IDENTITY

An asymmetrical center gives White activity and Black a queenside majority.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 Be7 8. O-O-O

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 12

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop quickly, use the d-file and kingside space, and decide where the king belongs.

BLACK'S PLAN

Pressure d4, use the c-file, and counter on the queenside before White's attack lands.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White often uses f4-f5; Black often uses ...d5 or ...b5-b4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Opposite-side castling turns pawn advances into direct attacks, so tempo is material.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Launching pawns while key defenders remain undeveloped.

MEMORY CUE

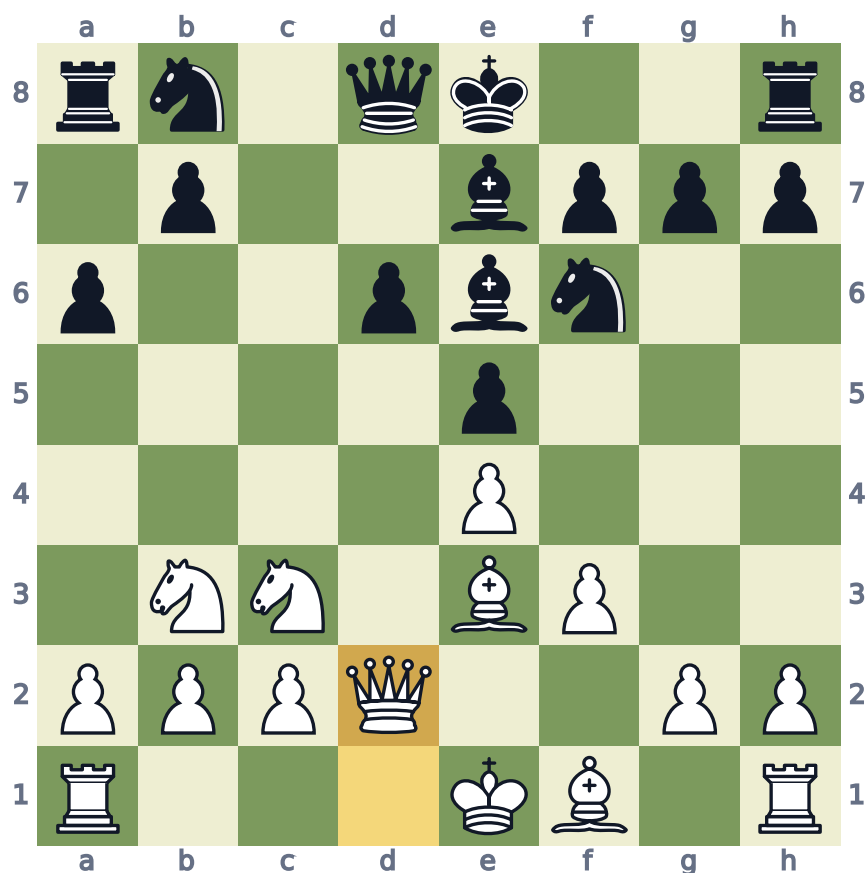
White gets time; Black gets structure and counterplay.

TRANSITION MAP 13 | B90-B99

Sicilian Najdorf

IDENTITY

Black's ...a6 controls b5 and prepares flexible queenside expansion.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e5 7. Nb3 Be6 8. f3 Be7 9. Qd2

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 13

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Choose a clear setup, finish queenside development, and attack before Black completes counterplay.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use ...b5, pressure the center, and pick ...e5 or ...e6 according to White's setup.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...b5-b4 is thematic; White often uses g4-g5 or f4-f5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The d5-square and d6-pawn are strategic targets, but grabbing them prematurely can lose time.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Memorizing sharp moves without understanding why ...a6 changes b5.

MEMORY CUE

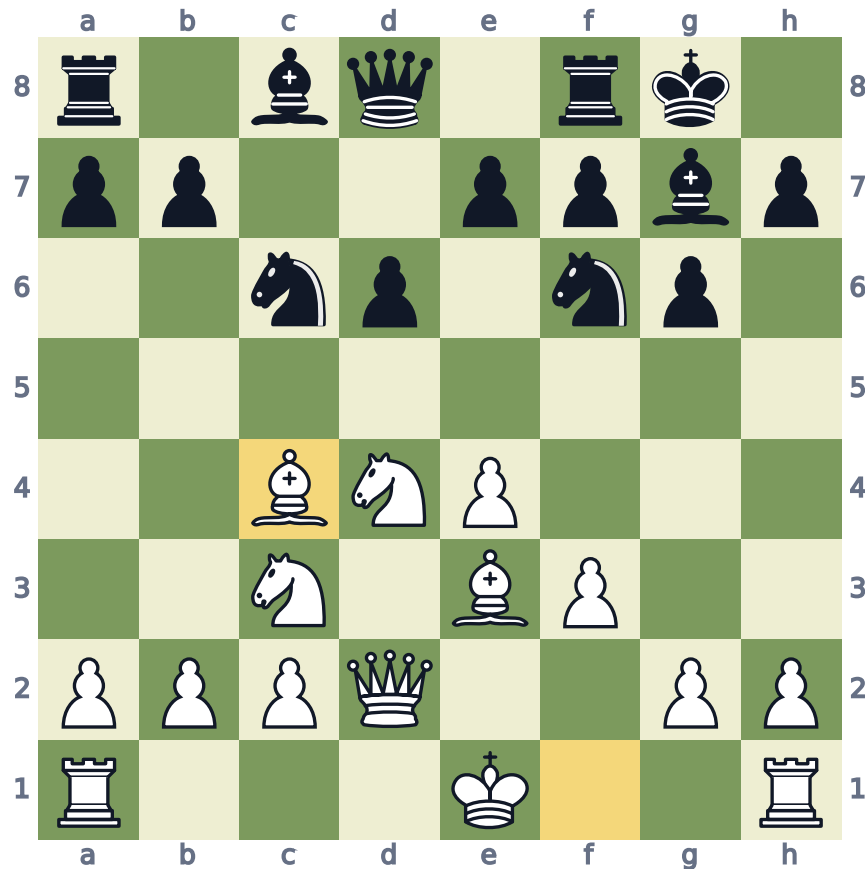
Control b5, expand with ...b5, fight for d5.

TRANSITION MAP 14 | B70-B79

Sicilian Dragon

IDENTITY

Black's fianchetto bishop attacks the center while both sides race on opposite wings.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3 Bg7 7. f3 O-O 8. Qd2 Nc6 9. Bc4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 14

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Castle long, trade the g7-bishop when useful, and push the h-pawn with full development.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use the c-file, pressure c3, and create queenside counterplay with ...b5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's h4-h5 and Black's ...b5 are the race-defining breaks.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Exchange sacrifices on c3 can destroy White's king shelter and center.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Starting the pawn race before the queen, bishops, and king are coordinated.

MEMORY CUE

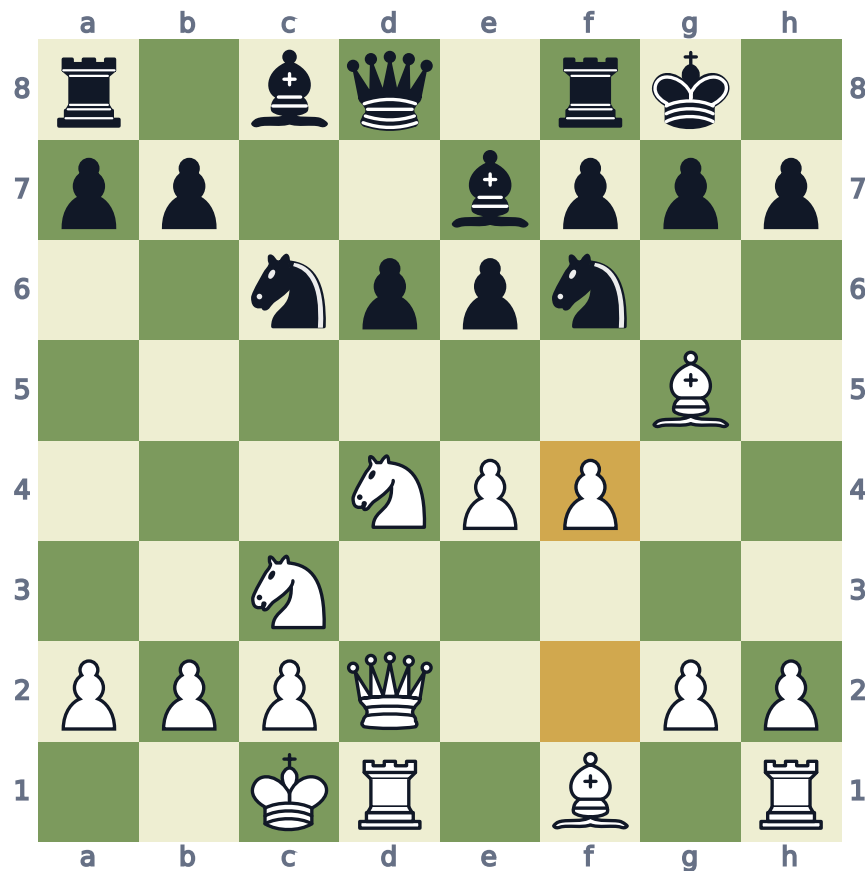
The g7-bishop and c-file power Black's attack.

TRANSITION MAP 15 | B56-B69

Classical Sicilian

IDENTITY

Black develops both knights naturally and keeps several central structures available.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bg5 e6 7. Qd2 Be7 8. O-O-O O-O 9. f4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 15

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the pin, castle long when appropriate, and build f4-f5 with piece support.

BLACK'S PLAN

Break the pin, pressure d4, and seek ...d5 or queenside play.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's f5 challenges e6; Black's ...d5 is the cleanest freeing break.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A capture on f6 can damage pawns or remove a defender, but it gives up the bishop pair.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Treating every pin as permission to attack without checking ...Nxd4 tactics.

MEMORY CUE

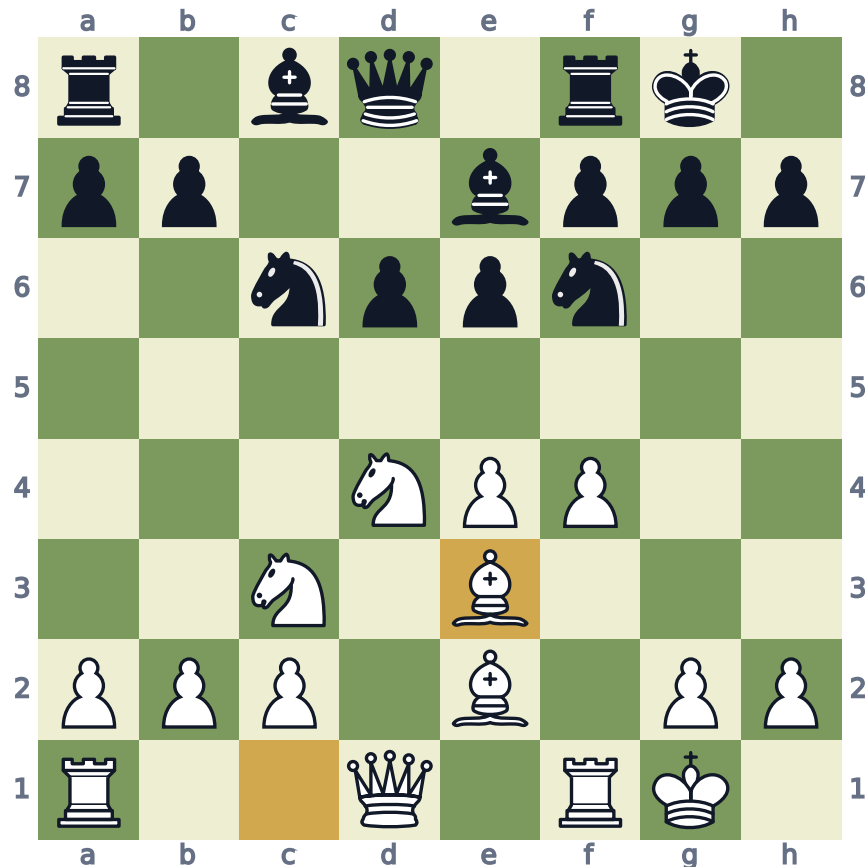
Natural development keeps Black's options open.

TRANSITION MAP 16 | B80-B89

Sicilian Scheveningen

IDENTITY

Black's compact e6-d6 center controls key squares and invites a dynamic attack-counterattack battle.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e6 6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. f4 Nc6 9. Be3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 16

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use f4, coordinate against the king, and watch the e5-square.

BLACK'S PLAN

Complete development, use ...Qc7 and ...b5, and time ...d5 precisely.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's f5 and Black's ...d5 or ...b5 are the critical levers.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Sacrifices on e6 can open lines when the f-pawn, queen, and bishops are aligned.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Pushing f5 before enough pieces can exploit the opened lines.

MEMORY CUE

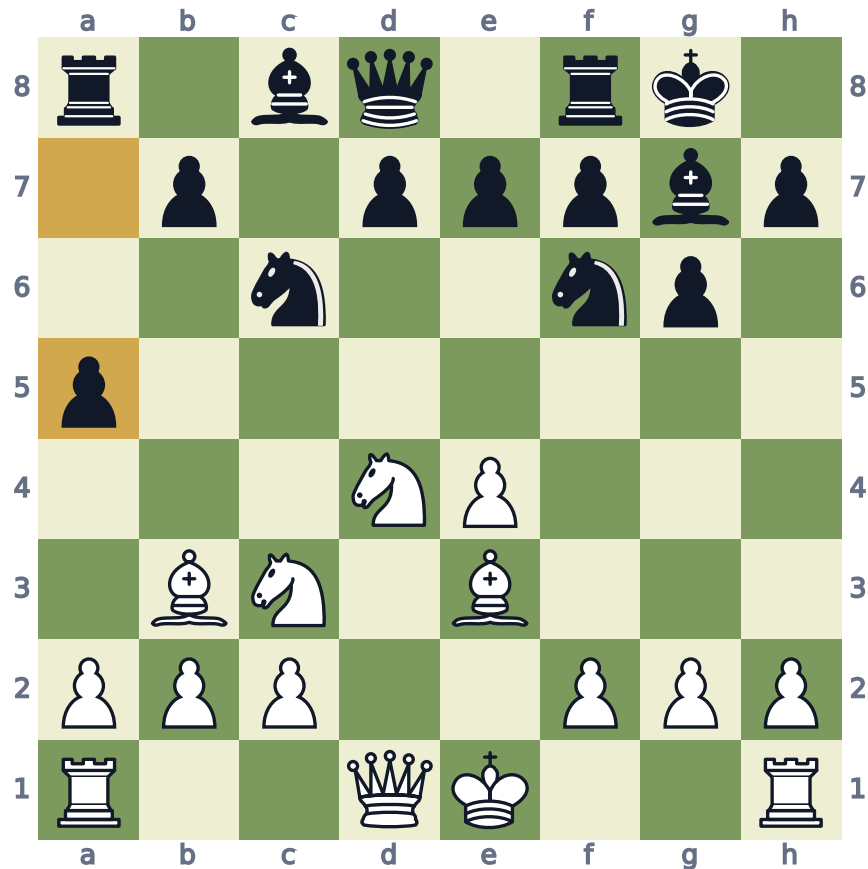
Compact center, flexible counterpunch.

TRANSITION MAP 17 | B34-B39

Accelerated Dragon

IDENTITY

Black fianchettoes without ...d6, keeping the option of a one-move ...d5 break.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 g6 5. Nc3 Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3 a5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 17

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Control d5, consider the Maroczy structure with c4, and avoid routine attacking moves.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use rapid activity, pressure d4, and strike with ...d5 when tactically sound.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...d5 is the opening's central question; White's c4 can restrain it.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Tactics on d4 and c3 appear when White's center is underdefended.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing as if this were a regular Dragon and allowing ...d5 in one move.

MEMORY CUE

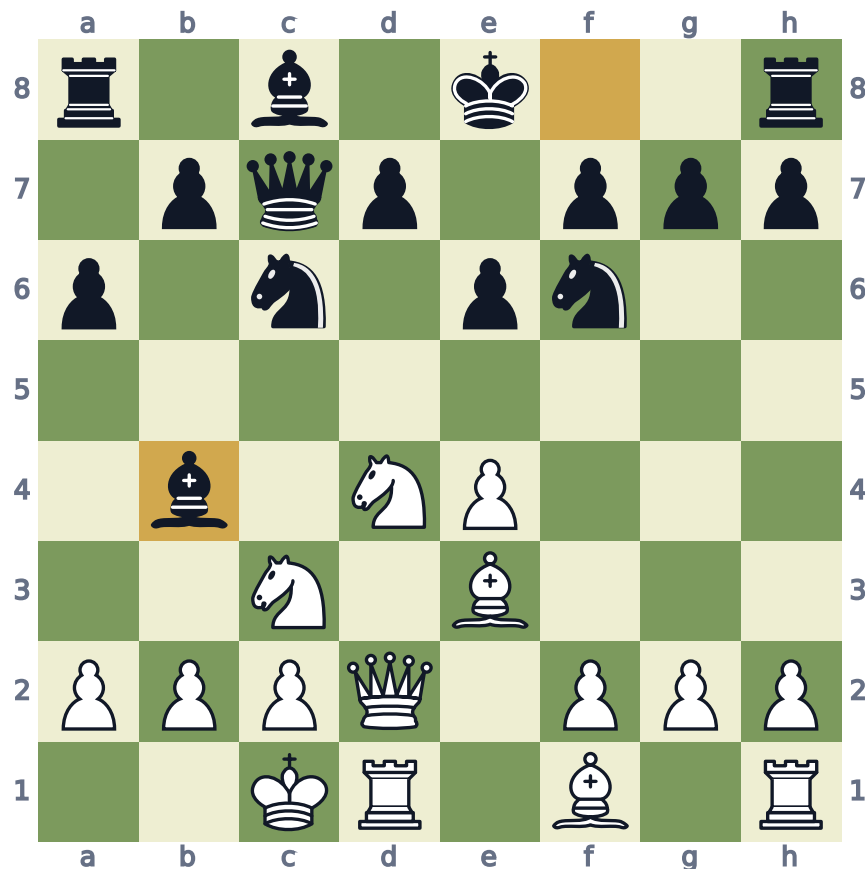
No ...d6 means ...d5 is always in the room.

TRANSITION MAP 18 | B46-B49

Sicilian Taimanov

IDENTITY

A flexible ...e6 and ...Nc6 setup uses the queen on c7 to support active piece play.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6 5. Nc3 Qc7 6. Be3 a6 7. Qd2 Nf6 8. O-O-O Bb4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 18

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop quickly, decide between long castling and a quieter setup, and watch ...Bb4.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use ...a6 and ...b5, pressure c3 and e4, and prepare ...Nf6 or ...d5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...d5 is ideal; ...b5 creates the usual queenside space.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

...Bb4 can pin or remove the c3-knight, increasing pressure on e4.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Castling long automatically into a prepared queenside expansion.

MEMORY CUE

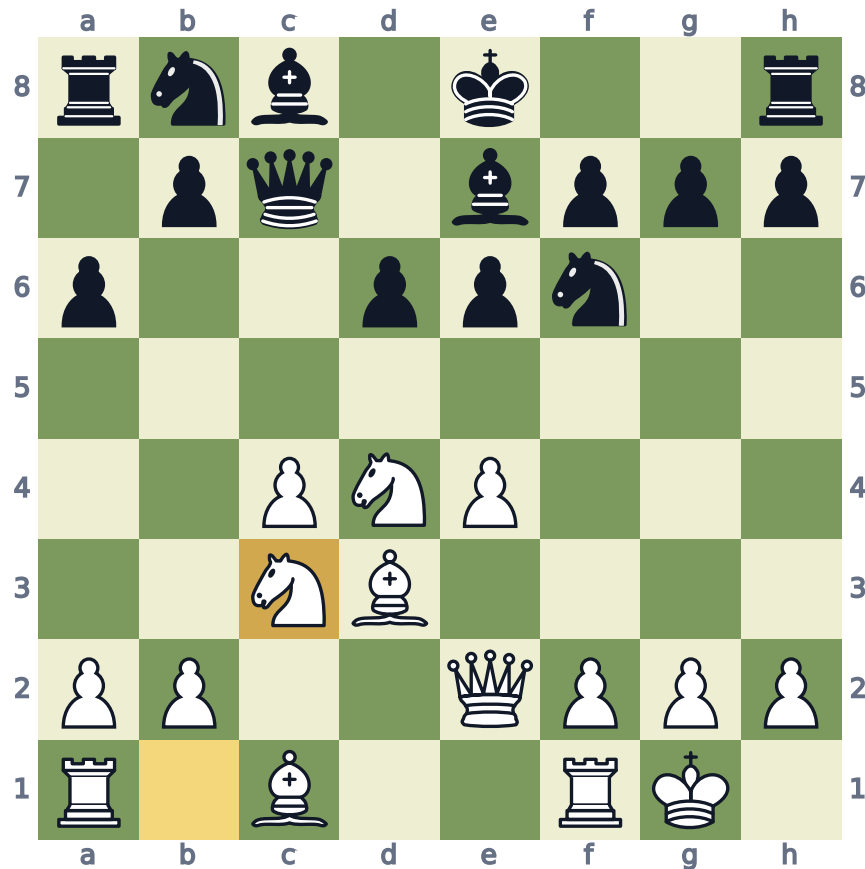
Queen on c7 makes e5, c3, and h2 matter.

TRANSITION MAP 19 | B41-B43

Sicilian Kan

IDENTITY

Black delays knight development to keep the queenside structure highly flexible.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 a6 5. Bd3 Qc7 6. O-O Nf6 7. Qe2 d6 8. c4 Be7 9. Nc3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 19

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Claim space with c4 when useful, finish development, and prevent an easy ...d5.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use ...b5, choose the best square for the b8-knight, and challenge White's space later.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...b5 is thematic; ...d5 is the freeing central goal.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The e4-pawn can be pressured by queen and knight, especially after White commits the c-pawn.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Expanding with c4 and f4 before making the king safe.

MEMORY CUE

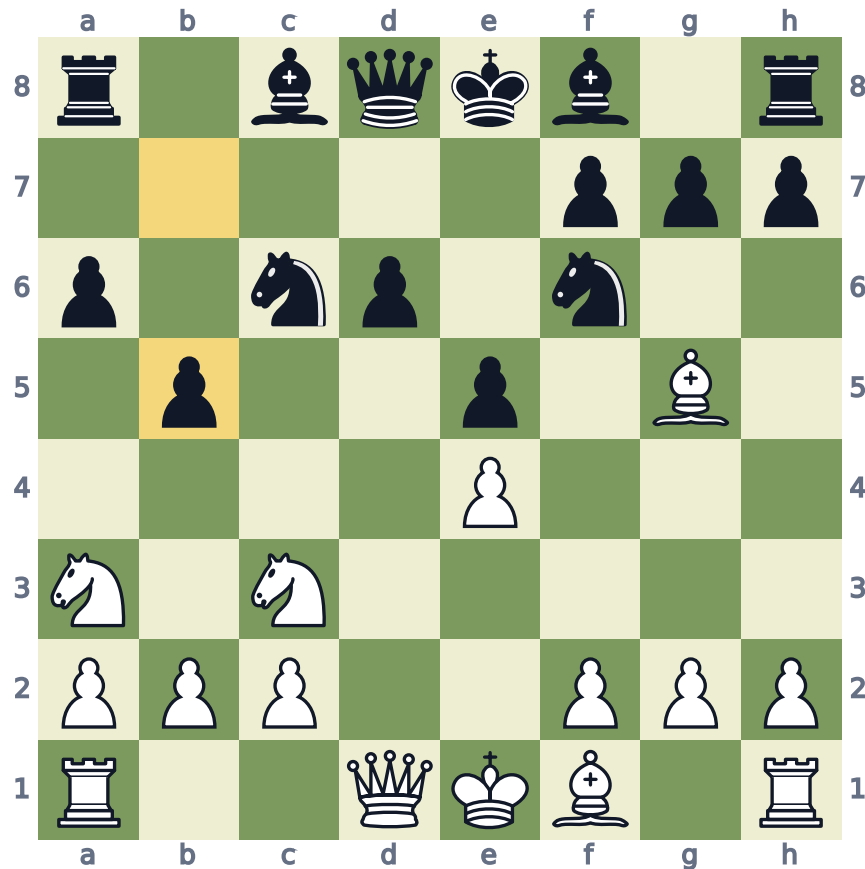
Delay the knight, keep every structure available.

TRANSITION MAP 20 | B33

Sicilian Sveshnikov

IDENTITY

Black accepts a backward d-pawn and weak d5-square in return for time and activity.



1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6 8. Na3 b5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 20

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use d5 as an outpost, pressure d6, and stop Black's active pawn expansion.

BLACK'S PLAN

Gain space with ...b5 and ...f5, use active pieces, and avoid passive defense of weaknesses.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...f5 energizes Black's kingside; White often uses c3 and Nc2-e3-d5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The b5-knight may be chased, but its route through a3 can help occupy d5 later.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Judging the position only by weak squares and ignoring Black's concrete activity.

MEMORY CUE

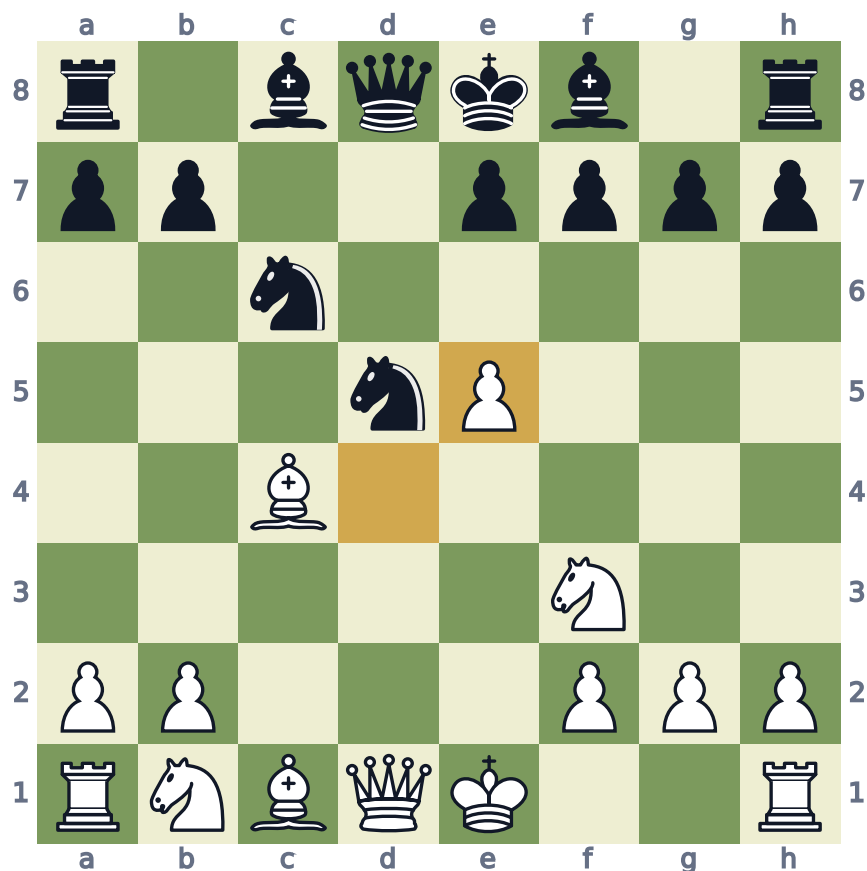
Static weaknesses are the price of dynamic time.

TRANSITION MAP 21 | B22

Sicilian Alapin

IDENTITY

White prepares d4 with a pawn, aiming for a broad classical center.



1. e4 c5 2. c3 Nf6 3. e5 Nd5 4. d4 cxd4 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. cxd4 d6 7. Bc4 dxe5 8. dxe5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 21

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Build the center, develop behind it, and use space without overprotecting every pawn.

BLACK'S PLAN

Attack e4 immediately, exchange central pawns, and make White prove the center is stable.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...d5 or ...d6 attacks the center; White may advance e5 for space.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The advanced e5-pawn can gain time on a knight but can also become a target.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Recapturing automatically without checking whether isolated pawns and piece activity favor Black.

MEMORY CUE

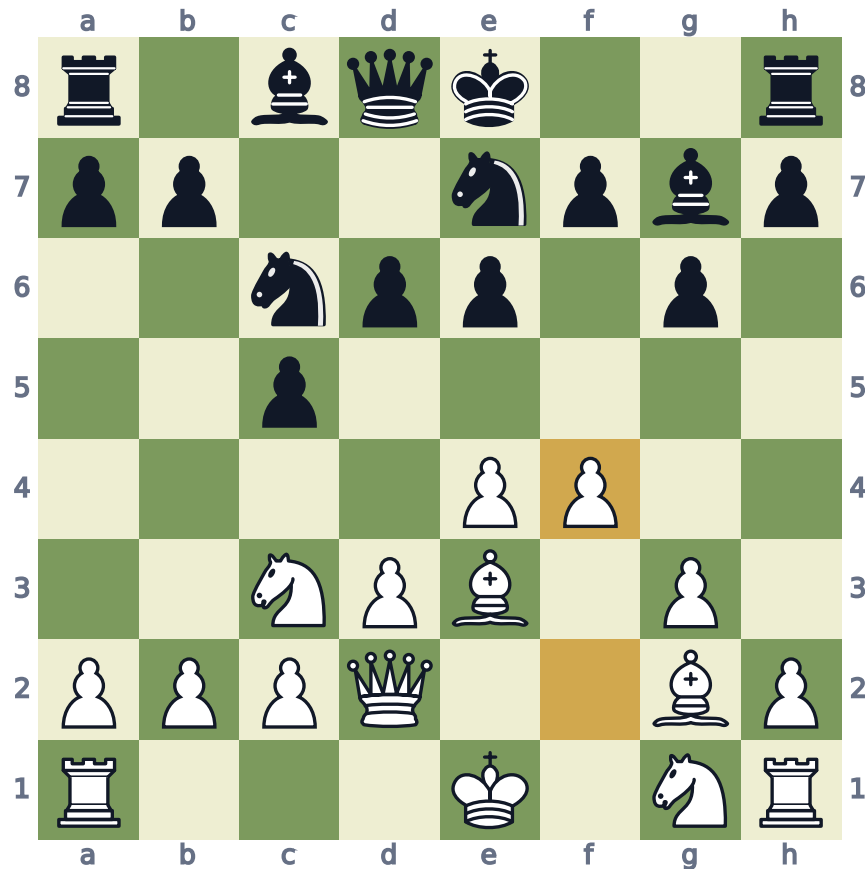
Build d4, then defend the center with pieces.

TRANSITION MAP 22 | B23-B26

Closed Sicilian

IDENTITY

White keeps the center closed and builds a slower kingside attack.



1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. g3 g6 4. Bg2 Bg7 5. d3 d6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 Nge7 8. f4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 22

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Fianchetto, castle, use f4-f5, and keep queenside counterplay under observation.

BLACK'S PLAN

Expand with ...Rb8 and ...b5, challenge d4 or e5, and avoid waiting passively.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's f5 and Black's ...b5 create the two-wing race.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A queen-bishop battery on the dark squares can support Bh6 and a kingside breakthrough.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Attacking with f4 before the g2-bishop and king are settled.

MEMORY CUE

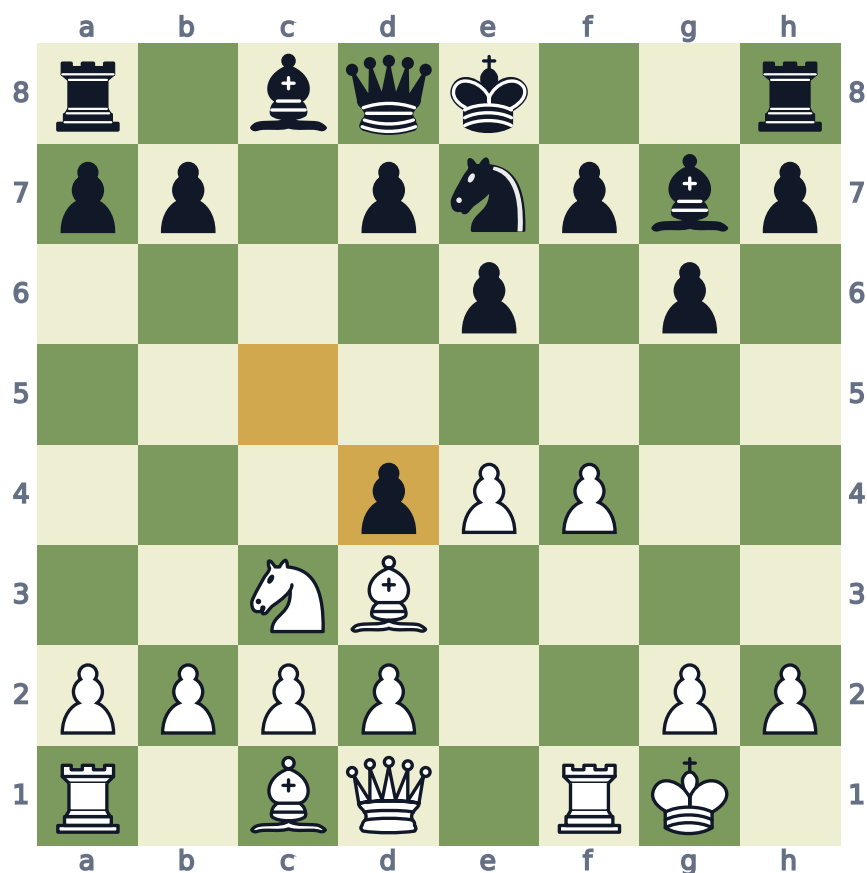
Closed center buys time - use it to finish the setup.

TRANSITION MAP 23 | B23

Grand Prix Attack

IDENTITY

White combines rapid development with f4 and direct kingside pressure.



1. e4 c5 2. Nc3 Nc6 3. f4 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. Bb5 Nd4 6. O-O e6 7. Bd3 Ne7 8. Nxd4 cxd4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 23

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Castle, place the queen toward e1-h4, and use f5 only when pieces support it.

BLACK'S PLAN

Counter in the center, use ...d5, and make the b5-bishop decide its future.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's f5 is thematic; Black's ...d5 is the central antidote.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Queen and bishop can converge on h7, but a closed center is needed for a safe flank attack.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing Qe1-h4 and f5 while the center can open against White's king.

MEMORY CUE

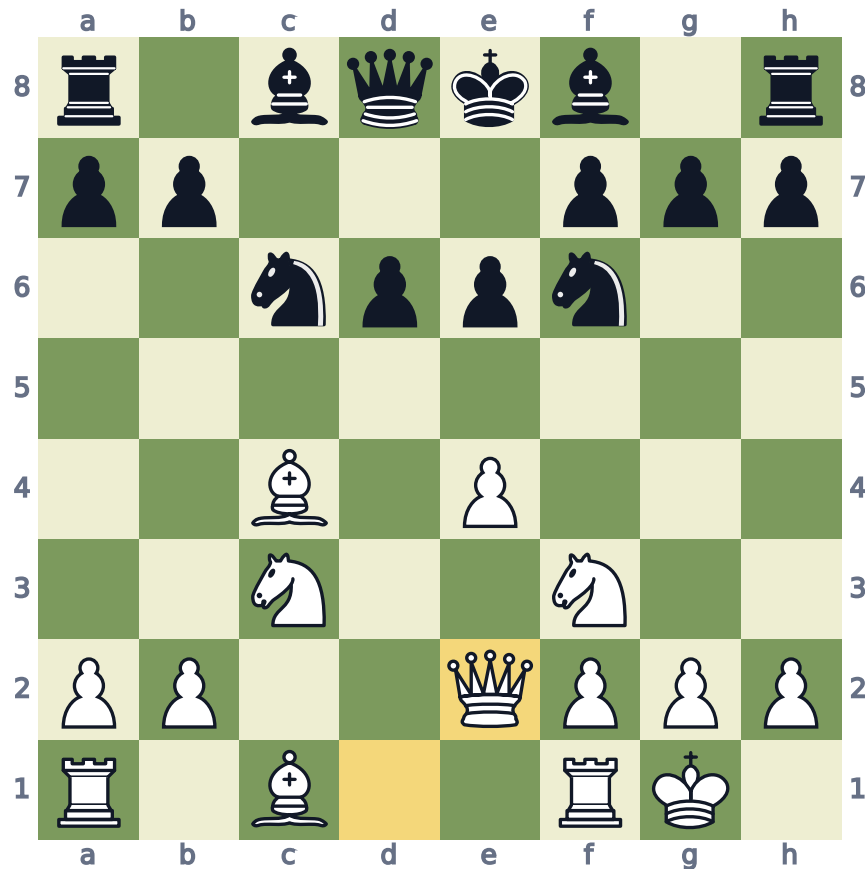
Castle first, aim at h7, calculate ...d5.

TRANSITION MAP 24 | B21

Smith-Morra Gambit

IDENTITY

White gives a pawn for open lines, fast development, and immediate initiative.



1. e4 c5 2. d4 cxd4 3. c3 dxc3 4. Nxc3 Nc6 5. Nf3 d6 6. Bc4 Nf6 7. O-O e6 8. Qe2

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 24

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Put rooks on open files, develop every piece, and attack before queens are traded.

BLACK'S PLAN

Complete development, return material if necessary, and blunt White's activity with accurate defense.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White may use e5; Black often seeks ...d5 to neutralize the initiative.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Rook pressure on d1 and sacrifices on e6 or f7 can punish one slow defensive move.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Trying to recover the pawn instead of using the open files it purchased.

MEMORY CUE

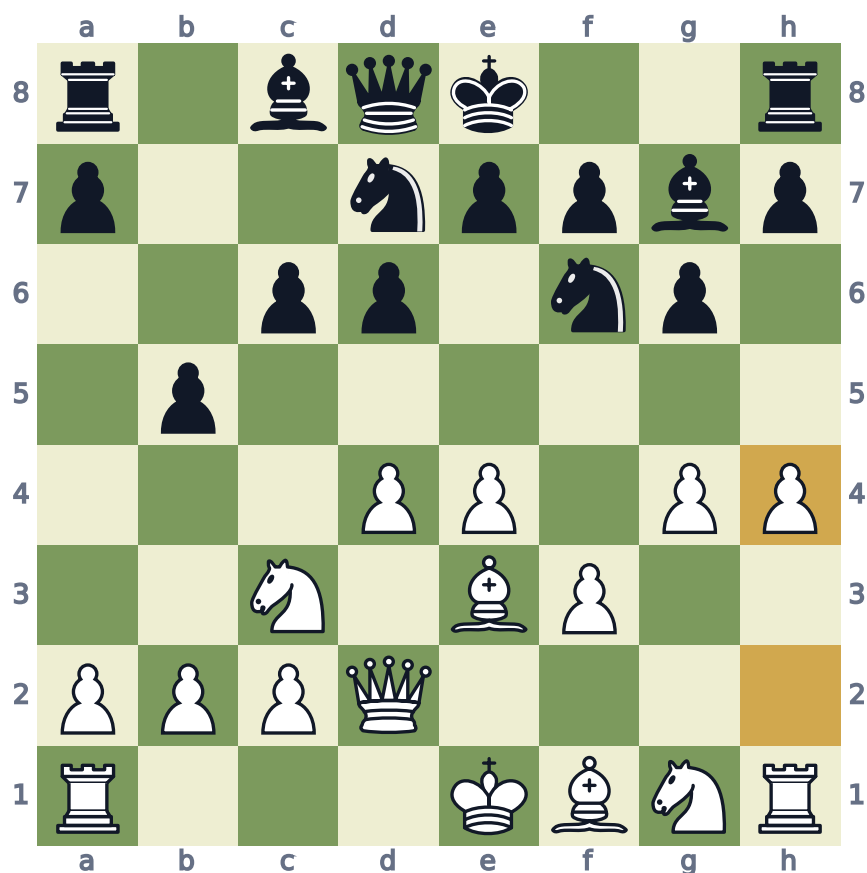
Development and open files are the compensation.

TRANSITION MAP 25 | B07-B09

Pirc Defense

IDENTITY

Black lets White build a center, then attacks it with pieces and pawn breaks.



1. e4 d6 2. d4 Nf6 3. Nc3 g6 4. Be3 Bg7 5. Qd2 c6 6. f3 b5 7. g4 Nbd7 8. h4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 25

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the space responsibly, choose a setup, and avoid creating targets faster than threats.

BLACK'S PLAN

Fianchetto, strike with ...e5 or ...c5, and create queenside play against an overextended center.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...e5 or ...c5 challenges the center; White often uses f4-f5 or h4-h5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

When White castles long, ...b5-b4 can remove the c3-knight that supports e4.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For Black, waiting without a break; for White, pushing every kingside pawn before development.

MEMORY CUE

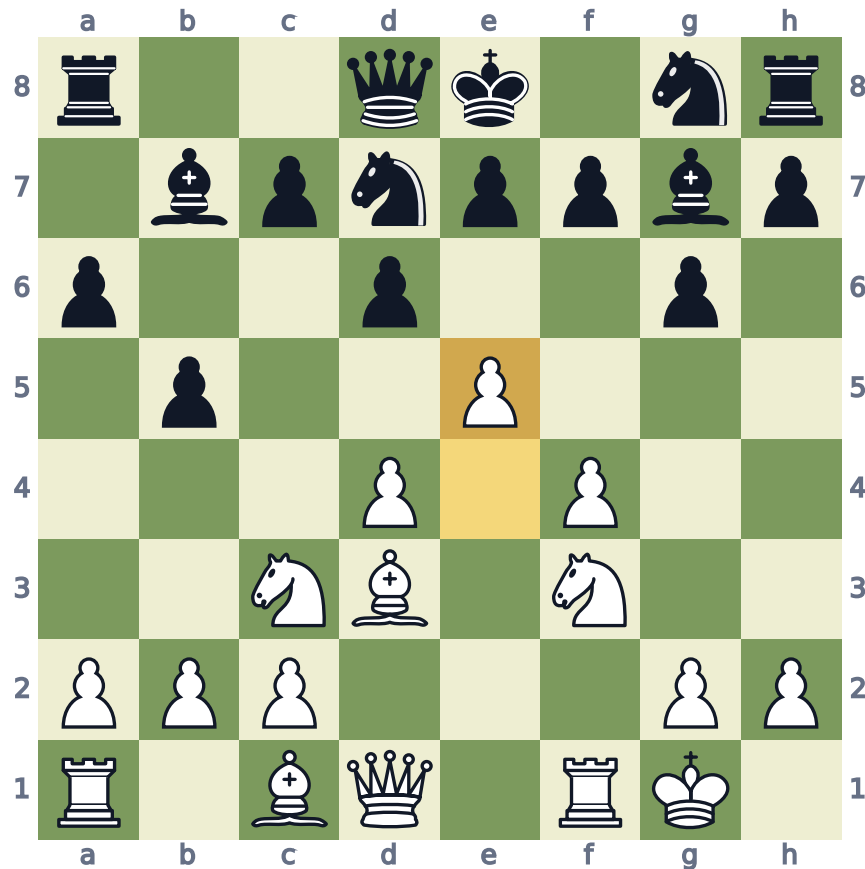
Invite the center, then hit its base.

TRANSITION MAP 26 | B06

Modern Defense

IDENTITY

Black delays committing the center and seeks flexible counterplay from a fianchetto.



1. e4 g6 2. d4 Bg7 3. Nc3 d6 4. f4 a6 5. Nf3 b5 6. Bd3 Nd7 7. O-O Bb7 8. e5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 26

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Occupy the center, develop behind it, and expand only when the king is safe.

BLACK'S PLAN

Attack the center with ...c5 or ...e5 and use queenside space without neglecting development.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 and ...e5 are Black's key choices; White's e5 can gain space and time.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A queenside pawn advance can threaten ...b4, dislodging the defender of e4.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Confusing flexibility with permission to leave pieces undeveloped.

MEMORY CUE

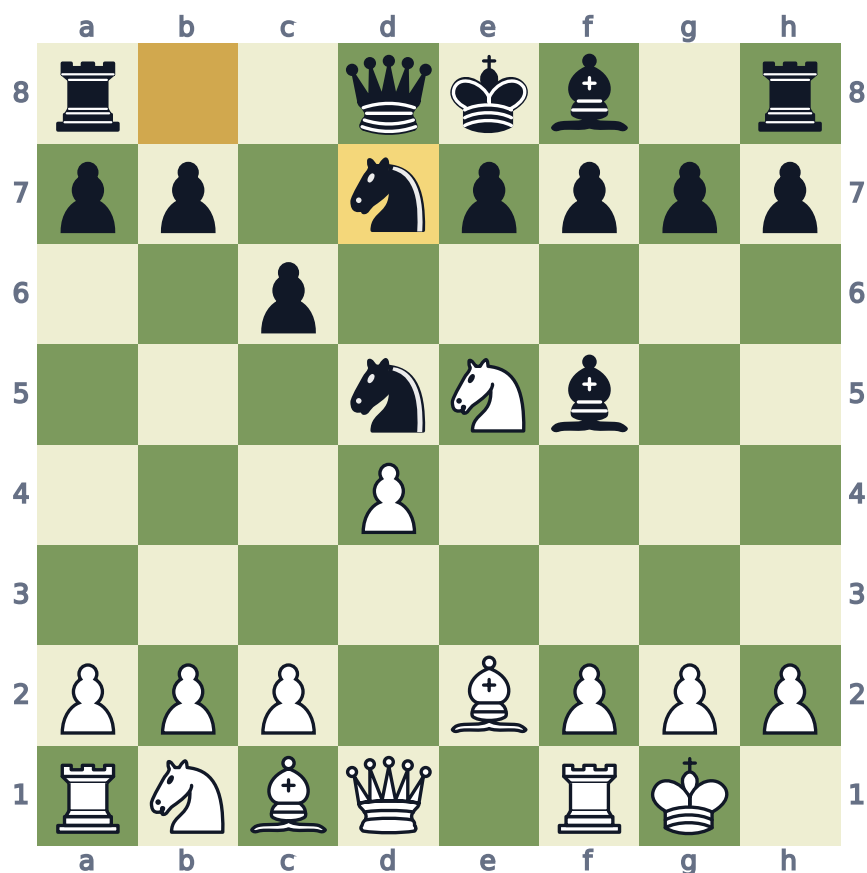
Delay commitment, not development forever.

TRANSITION MAP 27 | B02-B05

Alekhine Defense

IDENTITY

Black provokes White's pawns forward, then attacks the expanded center.



1. e4 Nf6 2. e5 Nd5 3. d4 d6 4. Nf3 dxe5 5. Nxe5 c6 6. Be2 Bf5 7. O-O Nd7

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 27

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the space but support it with pieces, not endless pawn moves.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge e5 and d4, exchange central pawns, and develop without getting trapped.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...d6 is the first challenge; ...c5 adds pressure to d4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The d5-knight looks exposed but can draw pawns forward and create weak squares behind them.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Chasing the knight with every available pawn and forgetting development.

MEMORY CUE

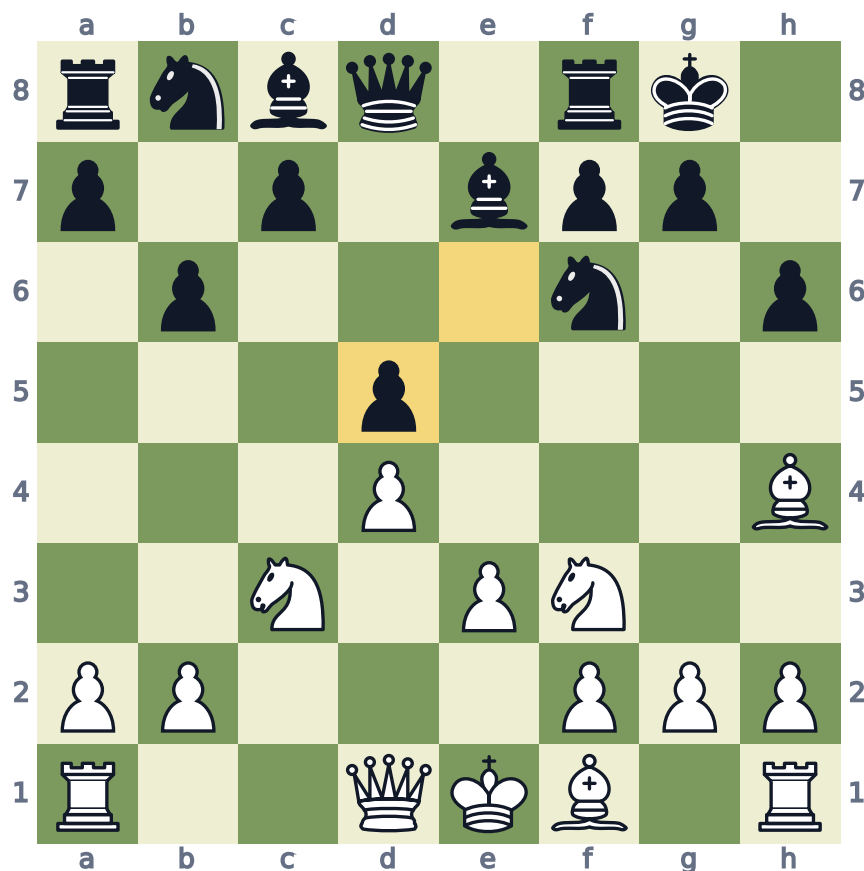
Space is useful only when pieces can use it.

TRANSITION MAP 28 | D06-D69

Queen's Gambit

IDENTITY

White challenges d5 with the c-pawn to gain central influence, not to donate material.



1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 28

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop, choose the right central exchange, and use queenside space or a minority attack.

BLACK'S PLAN

Maintain or resolve the center, free the c8-bishop, and contest the c-file.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's cxd5 may create a Carlsbad structure; Black wants ...c5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The c-pawn can be accepted, but holding it often costs Black too much time.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Treating the word gambit as a requirement to sacrifice or cling to a pawn.

MEMORY CUE

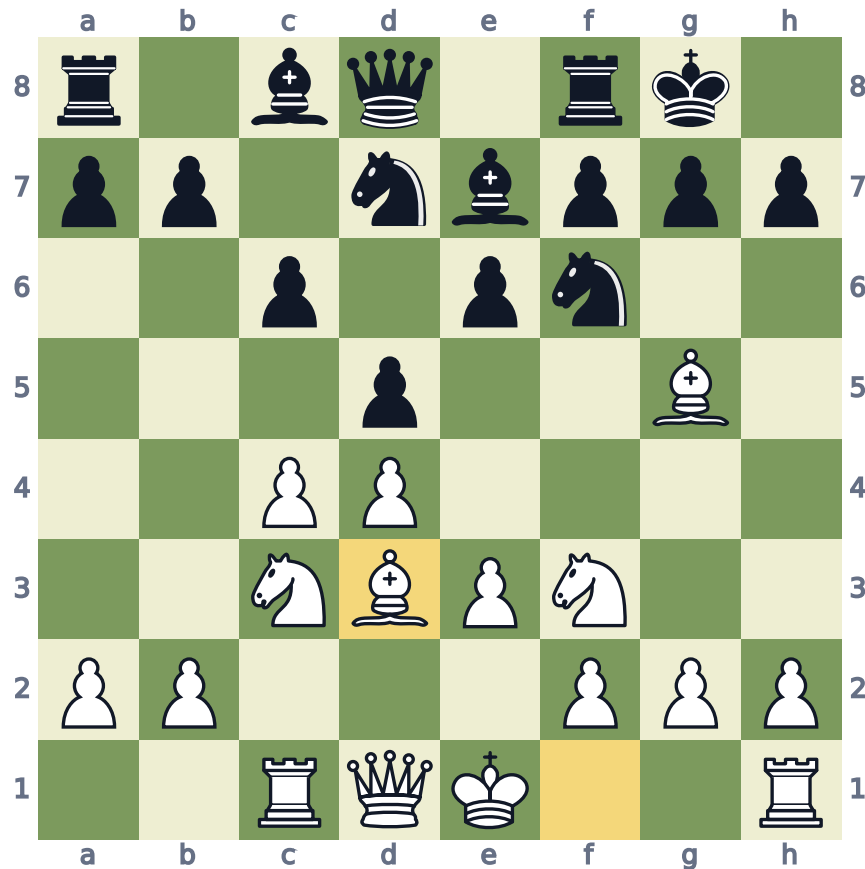
The c-pawn asks Black's d-pawn a structural question.

TRANSITION MAP 29 | D30-D69

Queen's Gambit Declined

IDENTITY

Black supports d5 with e6, accepting temporary limits on the light bishop.



1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 29

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop pressure, choose between cxd5 and a maintained tension, and use active piece placement.

BLACK'S PLAN

Complete development, prepare ...c5 or ...e5, and solve the c8-bishop.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 is the standard freeing break; ...e5 is possible with preparation.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Pins on f6 can make central captures tactical when the queen sits behind the knight.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For Black, defending d5 forever instead of freeing the position.

MEMORY CUE

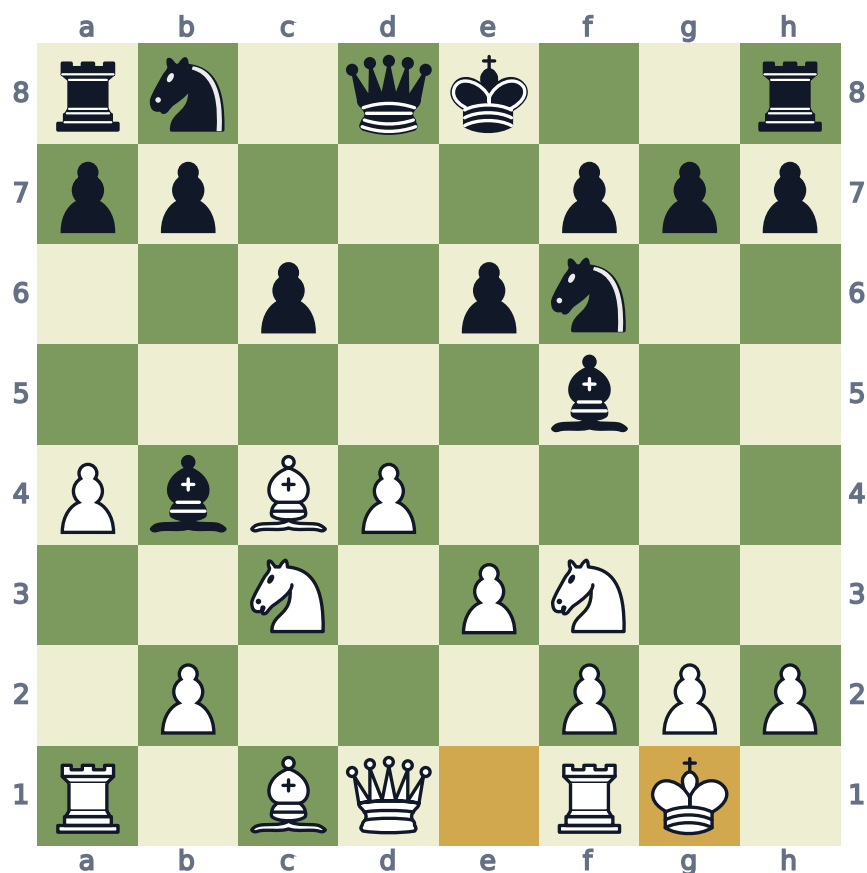
Support the center, then free the bishop.

TRANSITION MAP 30 | D10-D19

Slav Defense

IDENTITY

Black supports d5 with ...c6 while leaving the light bishop free.



1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 30

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop, recover c4 efficiently, and use e4 when the center permits it.

BLACK'S PLAN

Develop the bishop before ...e6, decide whether to hold c4 briefly, and challenge the center.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...c5 or ...e5 is the long-term freeing goal.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

...Bb4 can pin the c3-knight and increase pressure on e4 or c3.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Holding the c4-pawn with many queenside moves while White gains a huge center.

MEMORY CUE

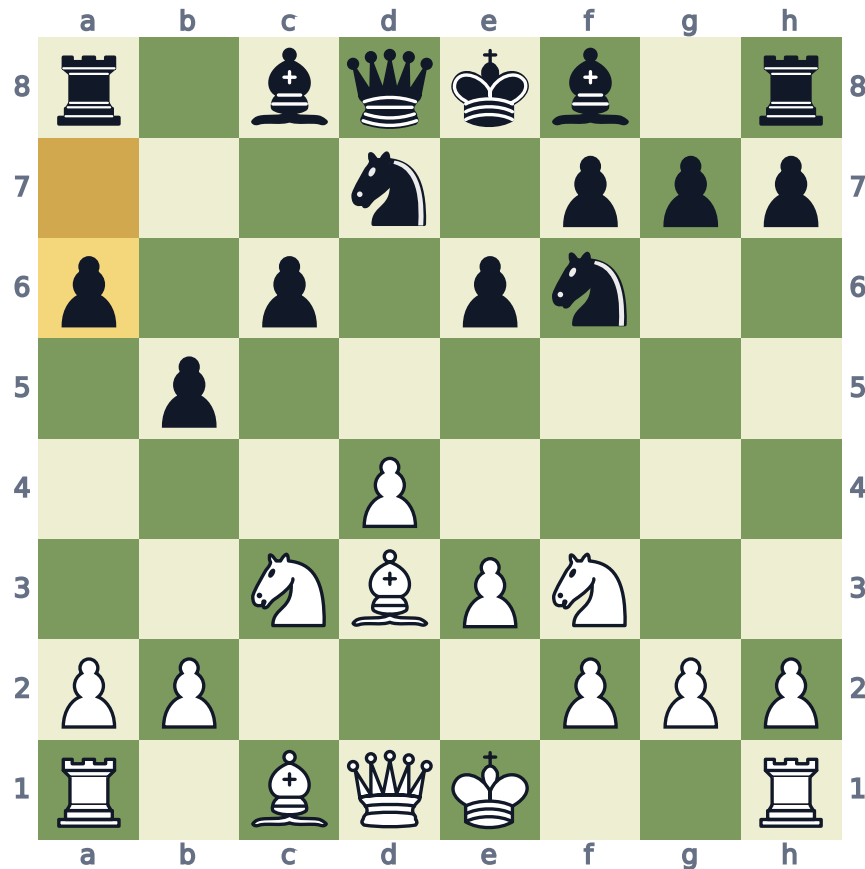
Support d5 without locking in the bishop.

TRANSITION MAP 31 | D43-D49

Semi-Slav Defense

IDENTITY

Black combines Slav solidity with ...e6, creating a compact but very dynamic structure.



1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Bd3 dxc4 7. Bxc4 b5 8. Bd3 a6

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 31

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop quickly, use e4 when possible, and exploit the time Black spends on queenside expansion.

BLACK'S PLAN

Support the center, gain time with ...b5, and prepare ...c5 or ...e5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 and ...e5 are the central liberating breaks.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The c4 capture can invite e4-e5 tactics if Black's king and center lag behind.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Memorizing sharp branches before understanding why Black takes on c4.

MEMORY CUE

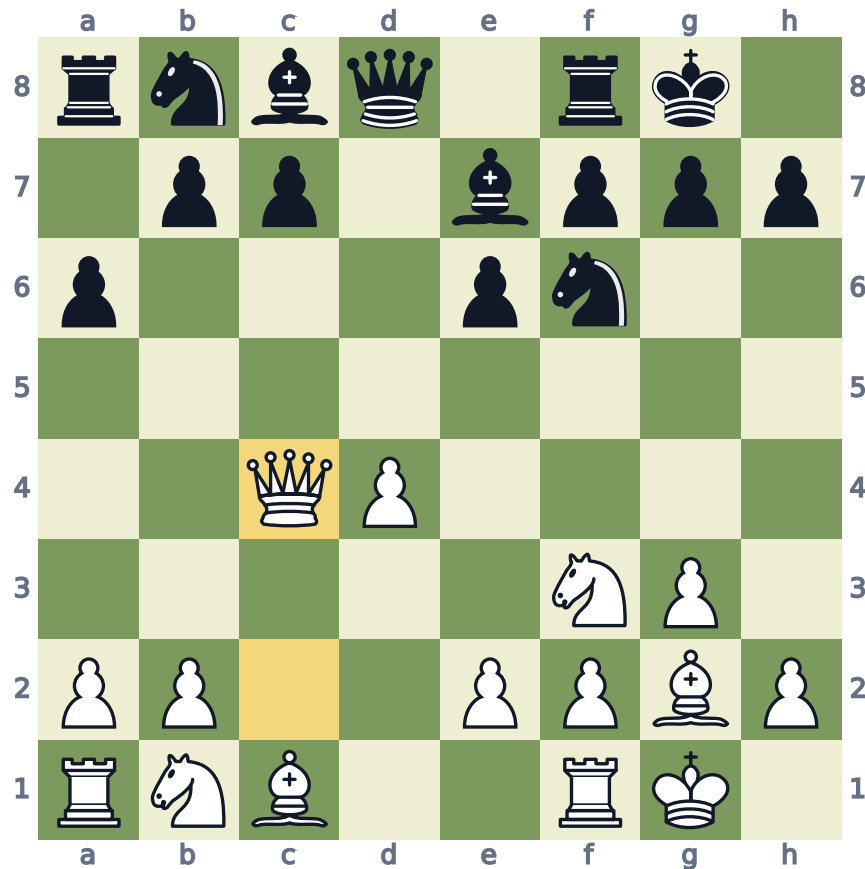
Compact shell, then a timed central explosion.

TRANSITION MAP 32 | E00-E09

Catalan Opening

IDENTITY

White combines Queen's Gambit pressure with a long bishop on g2.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. g3 d5 4. Bg2 Be7 5. Nf3 O-O 6. O-O dxc4 7. Qc2 a6 8. Qxc4

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 32

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the bishop's diagonal, recover c4 without losing time, and press queenside weaknesses.

BLACK'S PLAN

Resolve the center, neutralize the g2-bishop, and seek ...c5 or active queenside play.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White may use e4; Black's ...c5 challenges the center.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The g2-bishop can regain the c4-pawn indirectly when the diagonal opens.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Calling the bishop strong while leaving its diagonal blocked by White's own center.

MEMORY CUE

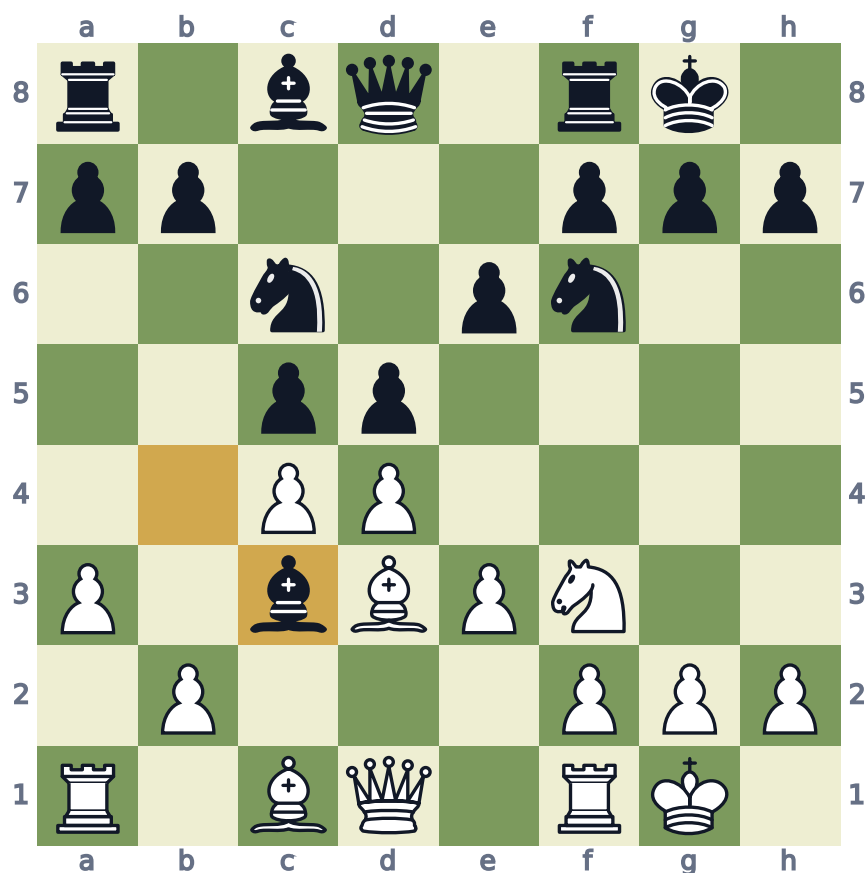
The bishop is the opening's long-range engine.

TRANSITION MAP 33 | E20-E59

Nimzo-Indian Defense

IDENTITY

Black pins the c3-knight and fights for e4 without occupying the center with pawns.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. a3 Bxc3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 33

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the bishop pair and space, or accept structure changes for central control.

BLACK'S PLAN

Pressure c3 and e4, strike with ...d5 or ...c5, and play against doubled pawns when created.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 and ...d5 are Black's central challenges; White often uses e4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Exchanging on c3 can damage pawns but surrenders the dark bishop, so timing matters.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Assuming doubled pawns are automatically weak regardless of bishop pair and center.

MEMORY CUE

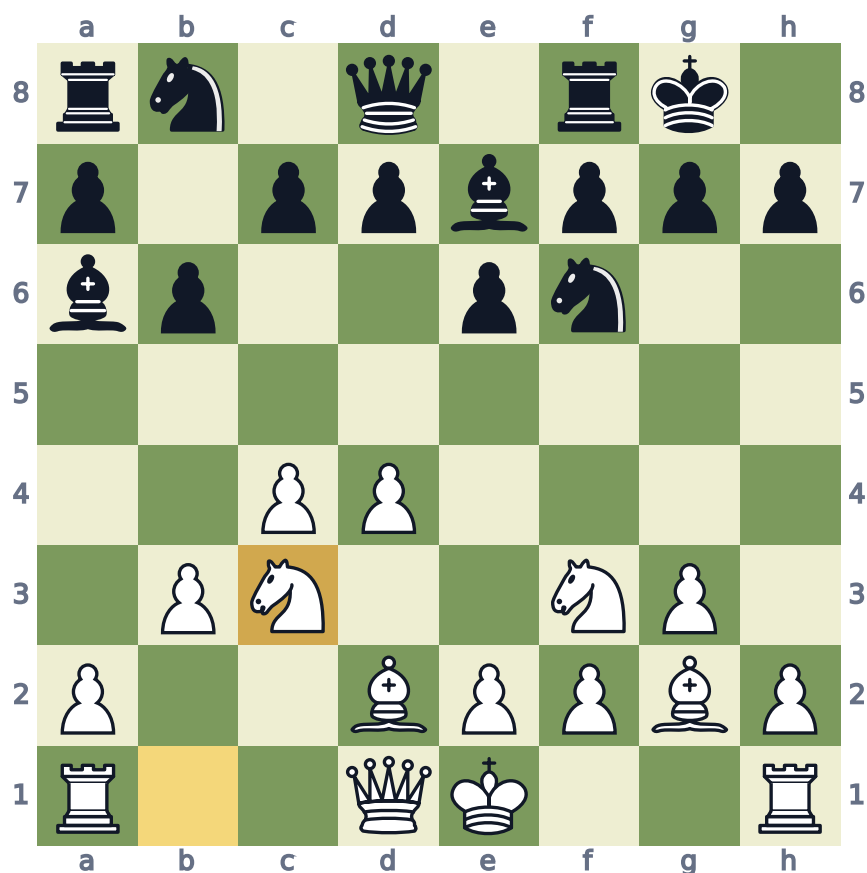
Pin the knight, control e4, choose the right structure.

TRANSITION MAP 34 | E12-E19

Queen's Indian Defense

IDENTITY

Black controls e4 with a queenside fianchetto and flexible piece pressure.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 b6 4. g3 Ba6 5. b3 Bb4+ 6. Bd2 Be7 7. Bg2 O-O 8. Nc3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 34

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Complete the fianchetto, occupy the center when safe, and gain space without weakening dark squares.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge the light squares, use ...Bb4+, and strike with ...c5 or ...d5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 is a common challenge; White may use d5 or e4 depending on timing.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The bishop check on b4 can force a piece placement that changes control of e4.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing e4 merely because it is the strategic goal without checking whether it is supported.

MEMORY CUE

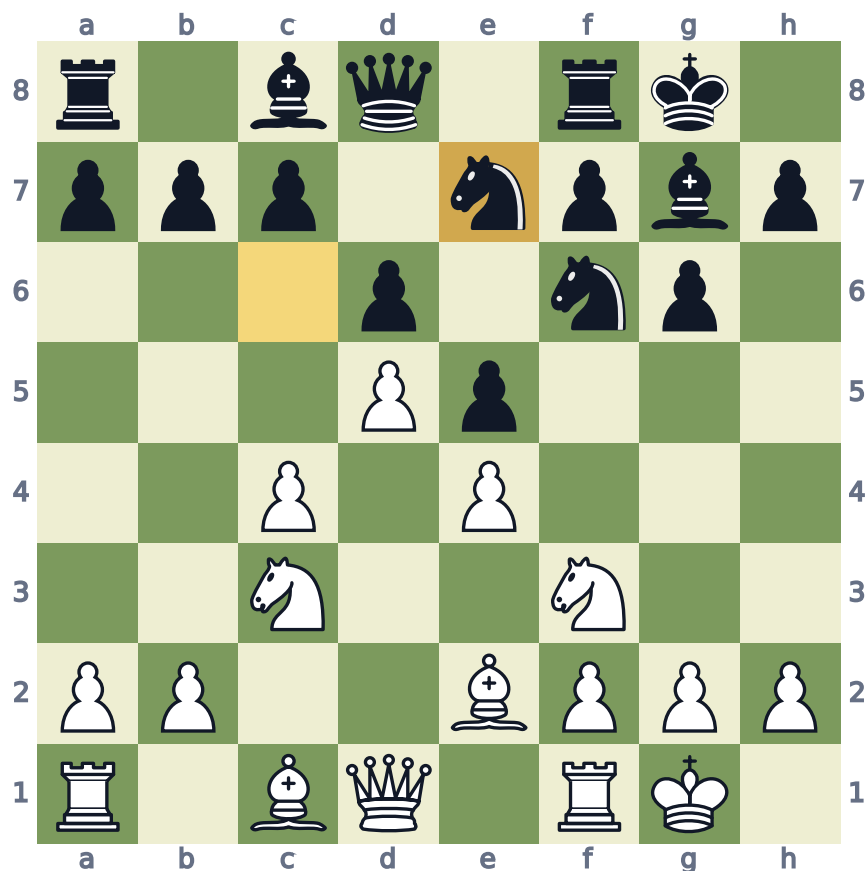
The b7-bishop points at e4 before it points at the king.

TRANSITION MAP 35 | E60-E99

King's Indian Defense

IDENTITY

A closed center often produces White's queenside space against Black's kingside attack.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 35

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use queenside space, prepare c5, and slow Black's attack without losing the initiative.

BLACK'S PLAN

Close with ...e5, maneuver, and break with ...f5 toward White's king.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's c5 and Black's ...f5 define the two-wing race.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Knight maneuvers to g6 or h5 support ...f5; White often uses b4 and c5 to open files.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Attacking on the wrong wing just because the pieces are nearby.

MEMORY CUE

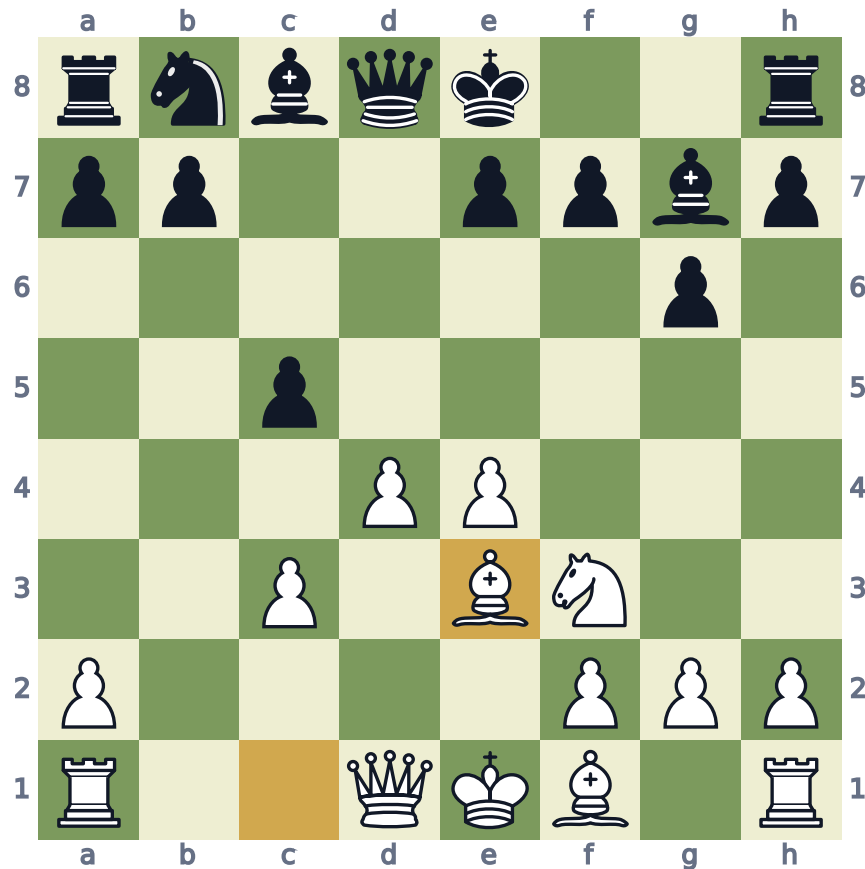
Follow the pawn-chain arrows: White queenside, Black kingside.

TRANSITION MAP 36 | D70-D99

Grunfeld Defense

IDENTITY

Black lets White build a broad center, then attacks it immediately from a distance.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. e4 Nxc3 6. bxc3 Bg7 7. Nf3 c5 8. Be3

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 36

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the center to gain space and activity while keeping its base defended.

BLACK'S PLAN

Pressure d4 with the g7-bishop, c5, and piece activity; trade pieces that support the center.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...c5 is the main strike; ...e5 may add a second challenge.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The d4-pawn can be overloaded because it supports e5 ideas and blocks the bishop diagonal.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For White, believing a large center maintains itself; for Black, attacking it without development.

MEMORY CUE

Build the center, then prove it can survive pressure.

TRANSITION MAP 37 | A60-A79

Modern Benoni

IDENTITY

An asymmetrical pawn structure gives White central space and Black queenside counterplay.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 e6 4. Nc3 exd5 5. cxd5 d6 6. e4 g6 7. f4 Bg7

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 37

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use e4-f4, control e5, and convert space into a kingside or central initiative.

BLACK'S PLAN

Pressure e4, expand with ...b5, and use the dark-square bishop.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e5 or f5 competes with Black's ...b5.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Tactics on e4 and b2 arise when the long diagonal and central pins combine.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For Black, waiting behind the space disadvantage without queenside counterplay.

MEMORY CUE

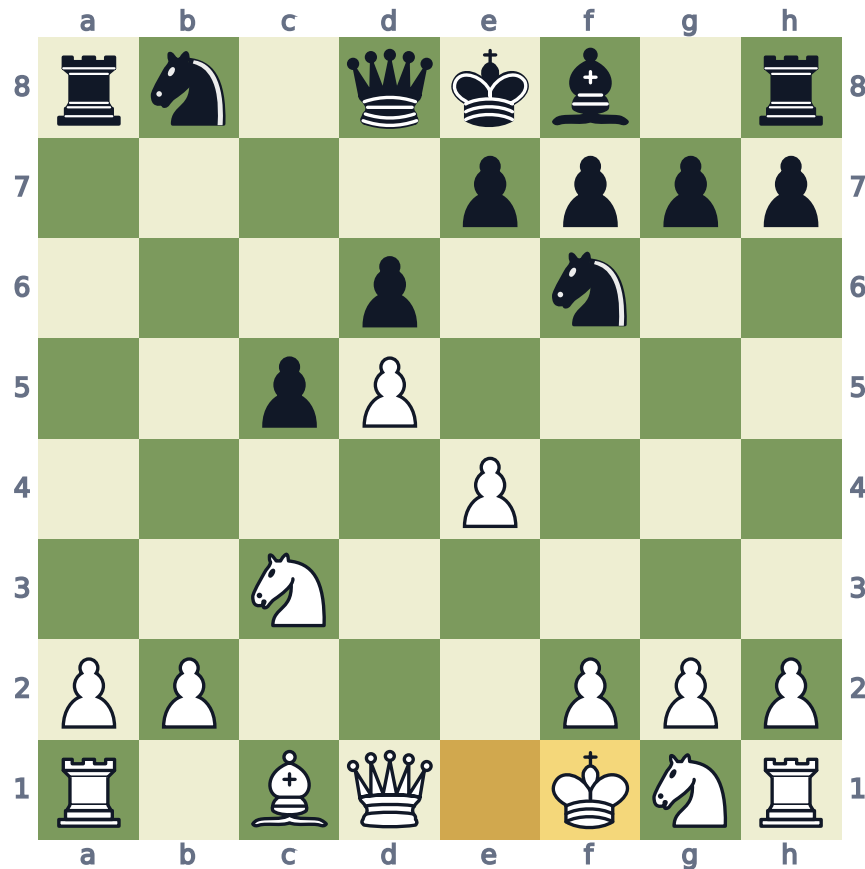
White owns space; Black must create motion.

TRANSITION MAP 38 | A57-A59

Benko Gambit

IDENTITY

Black sacrifices a queenside pawn for lasting files, diagonals, and pressure.



1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 c5 3. d5 b5 4. cxb5 a6 5. bxa6 Bxa6 6. Nc3 d6 7. e4 Bxf1 8. Kxf1

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 38

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Consolidate the extra pawn, complete development, and neutralize the a- and b-file pressure.

BLACK'S PLAN

Activate rooks on the queenside, fianchetto, and keep the initiative rather than chasing material.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...e6 attacks d5; ...b4 can disrupt White's queenside pieces.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The a6-bishop trade removes castling rights and can make the king awkward even without immediate tactics.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

For Black, assuming compensation exists without placing rooks and bishop on their active lines.

MEMORY CUE

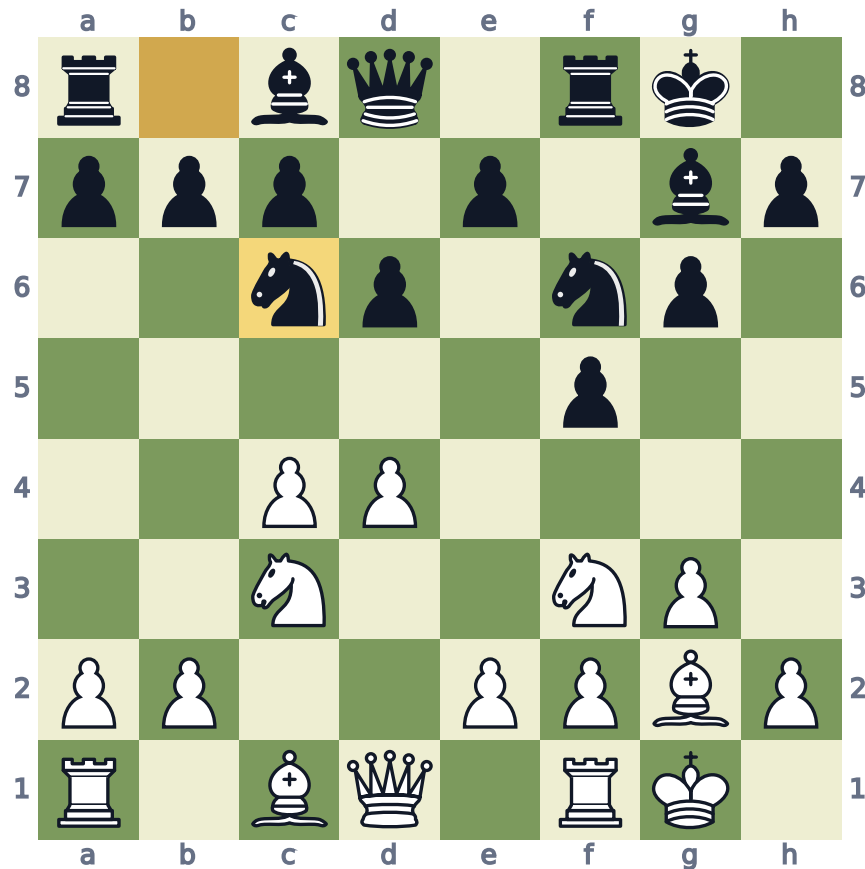
The pawn buys files and lasting pressure.

TRANSITION MAP 39 | A80-A99

Dutch Defense

IDENTITY

Black controls e4 with the f-pawn and accepts kingside looseness for active play.



1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 39

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Pressure the dark squares, use e4 when prepared, and exploit any weak king diagonals.

BLACK'S PLAN

Build around e4, complete development, and choose ...e5 or queenside support according to the setup.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

...e5 is the thematic central break; White often answers with d5 or e4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The diagonal toward h5 and the weakened e6-square can matter after an early ...f5.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Pushing ...f5 and ...g5 without making the king safe.

MEMORY CUE

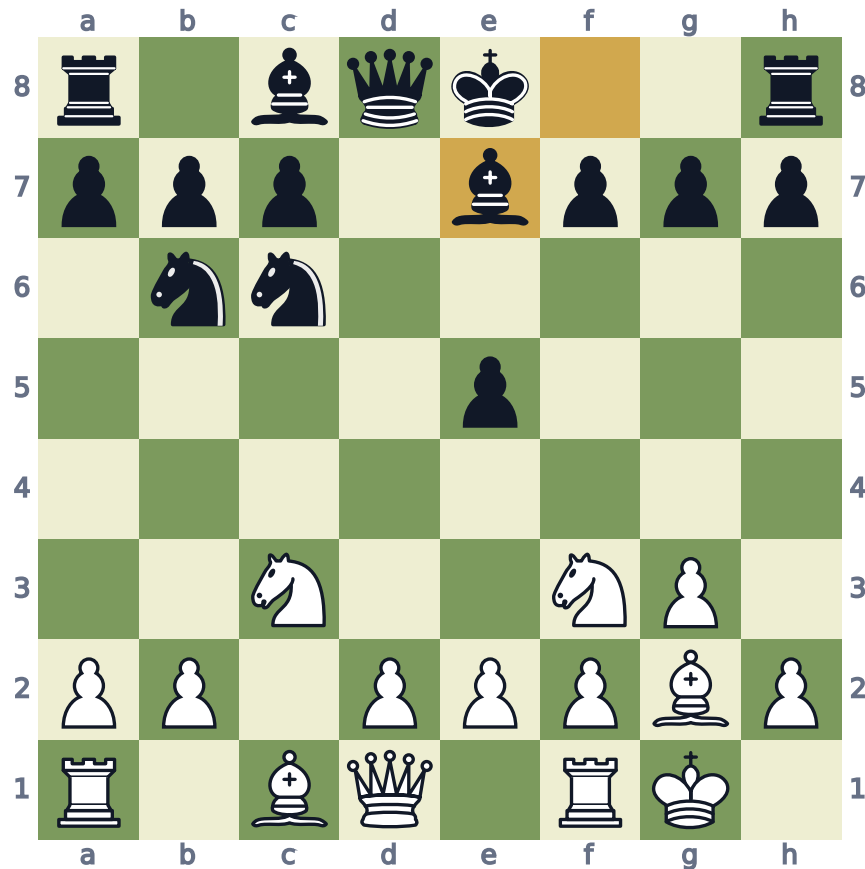
Control e4, then justify the loosened kingside.

TRANSITION MAP 40 | A10-A39

English Opening

IDENTITY

White controls d5 from the flank and delays the final central structure.



1. c4 e5 2. Nc3 Nf6 3. g3 d5 4. cxd5 Nxd5 5. Bg2 Nb6 6. Nf3 Nc6 7. O-O Be7

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 40

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Fianchetto, finish development, and choose d4 or a queenside expansion based on Black's setup.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use central space, develop quickly, and prevent White from gaining a free d4 break.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's d4 transforms the position; Black may use ...f5 or ...d4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The g2-bishop and c-pawn combine against b7 and d5 when diagonals open.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing a slow flank setup without watching Black occupy the whole center.

MEMORY CUE

Control the center from the side, then choose when to occupy it.

TRANSITION MAP 41 | A04-A09

Reti Opening

IDENTITY

White develops and controls central squares before committing central pawns.



1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. O-O Bg7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 41

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Fianchetto, castle, then choose e4, c4, or d4 according to Black's structure.

BLACK'S PLAN

Claim useful space without overextending and challenge White's delayed center.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e4 or c4 defines the later opening; Black uses ...c5 to secure space.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A timely e4 can attack the center and open the e-file after both kings castle.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Confusing flexibility with aimlessness and making only quiet moves.

MEMORY CUE

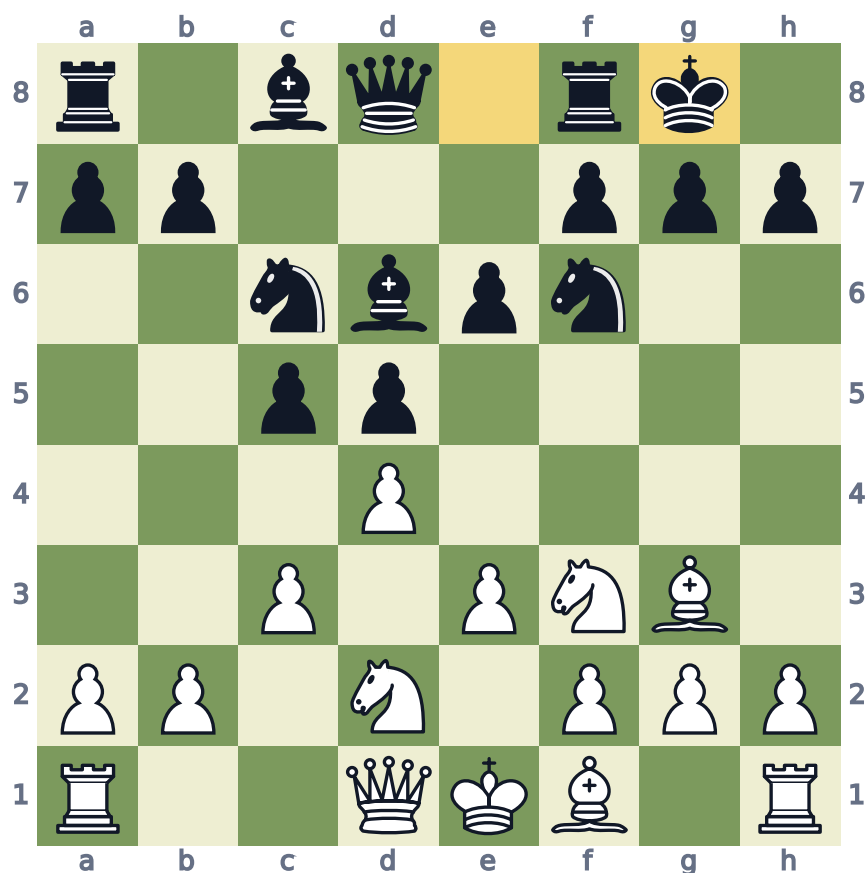
Develop first, reveal the center later.

TRANSITION MAP 42 | D02

London System

IDENTITY

White builds a dependable development scheme with the bishop outside the pawn chain.



1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Bf4 e6 4. e3 c5 5. c3 Nc6 6. Nbd2 Bd6 7. Bg3 O-O

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 42

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Complete the triangle, castle, and choose e4 or queenside play based on Black's center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge d4 early, develop actively, and avoid treating the setup as untouchable.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e4 is the main ambition; Black's ...c5 immediately questions d4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The h2-b8 diagonal and Ne5 can create kingside pressure once development is complete.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing the same diagram regardless of Black's threats.

MEMORY CUE

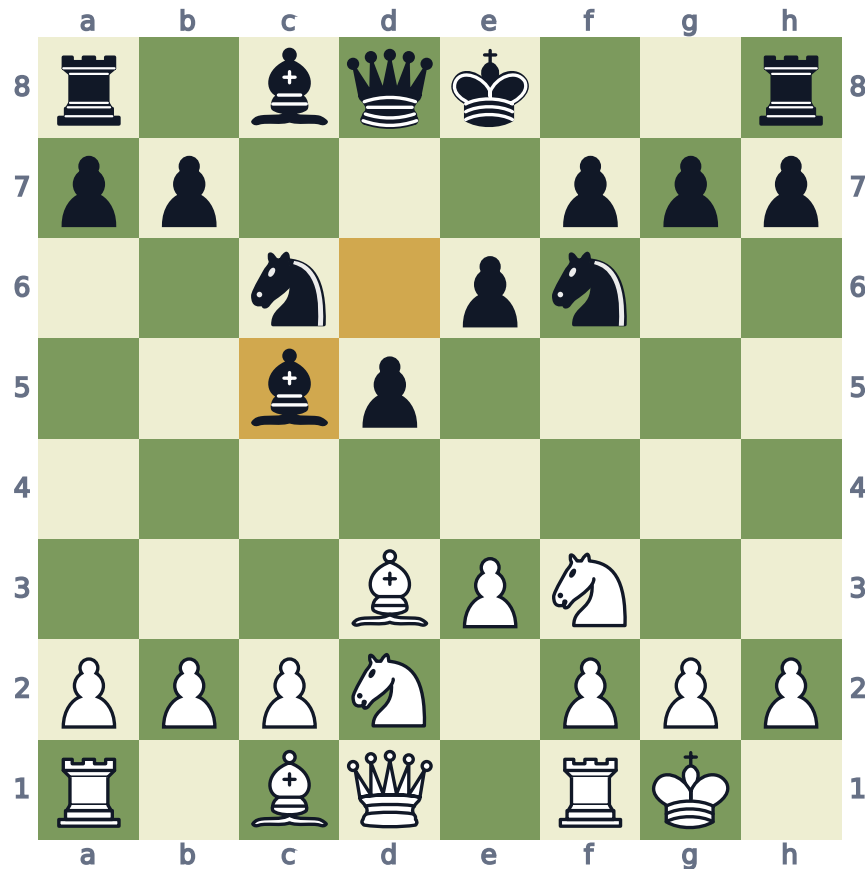
A system is a map, not autopilot.

TRANSITION MAP 43 | D04-D05

Colle System

IDENTITY

White builds a compact center and prepares the freeing e4 advance.



1. d4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. e3 e6 4. Bd3 c5 5. O-O Nc6 6. Nbd2 Bd6 7. dxc5 Bxc5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 43

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop safely, castle, and arrange e4 when Black cannot punish the center.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use ...c5, develop actively, and prevent an uncontested e4 break.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e4 is the point of the system; Black's ...c5 attacks its base.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

After e4 and e5, bishop and queen can build pressure on h7.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Preparing e4 forever without checking when it is already possible.

MEMORY CUE

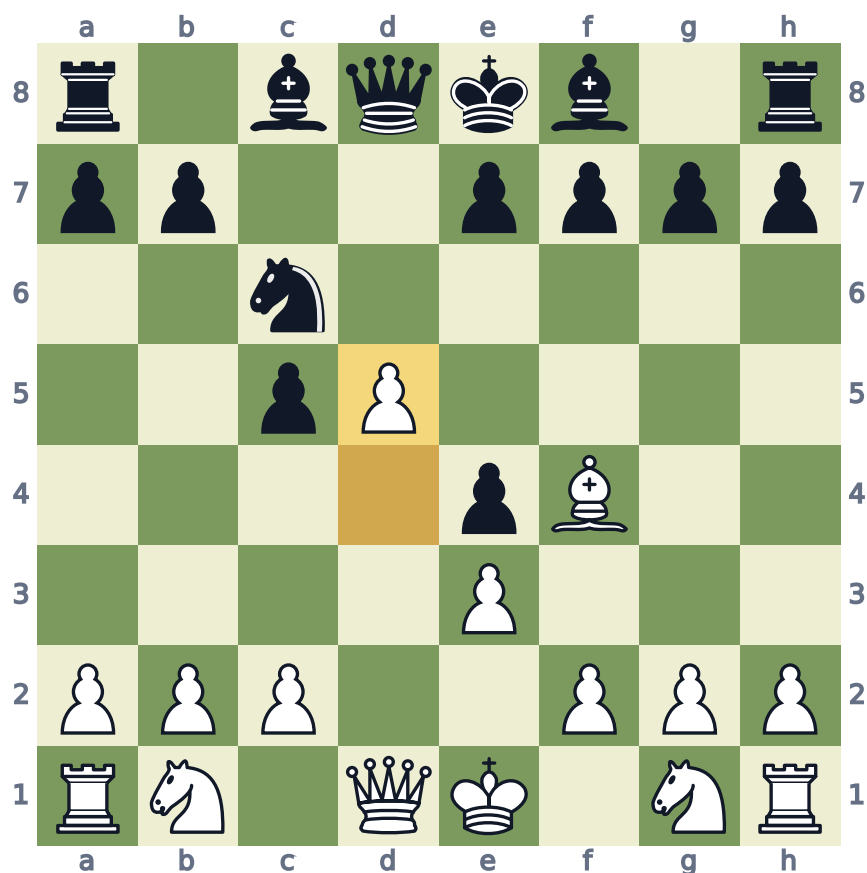
Every quiet move prepares one central release: e4.

TRANSITION MAP 44 | A45

Trompowsky Attack

IDENTITY

White develops the bishop aggressively and questions the f6-knight before c4.



1. d4 Nf6 2. Bg5 Ne4 3. Bf4 d5 4. e3 c5 5. Bd3 Nc6 6. Bxe4 dxe4 7. d5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 44

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Use the pin or provoke a knight move, then build a center suited to the changed piece placement.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge the bishop, occupy the center, and use the bishop pair if White exchanges.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's d5 gains space; Black's ...c5 attacks d4.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Bxe4 can change the pawn structure and open diagonals for both sides.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Giving up the bishop merely to damage pawns when the resulting center favors Black.

MEMORY CUE

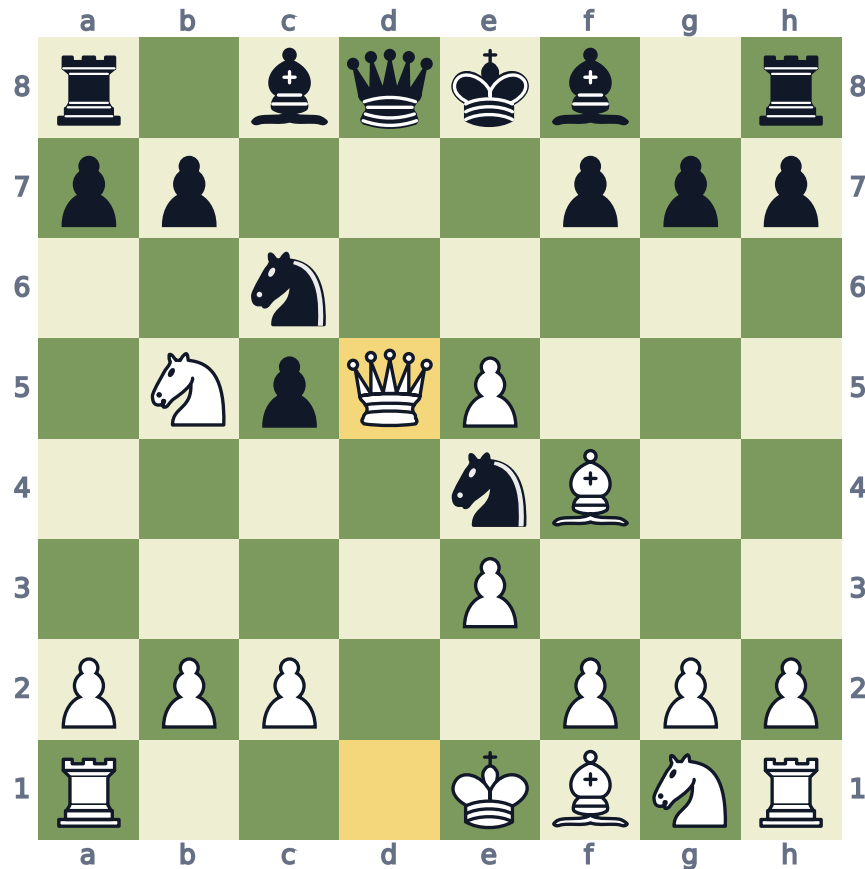
Ask the knight a question, then use its answer.

TRANSITION MAP 45 | D00-D02

Jobava London System

IDENTITY

White combines London development with Nc3 and tactical pressure on b5, c7, and d5.



1. d4 d5 2. Nc3 Nf6 3. Bf4 c5 4. e3 Nc6 5. Nb5 e5 6. dxe5 Ne4 7. Qxd5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 45

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop energetically, watch the b5-knight jump, and calculate central tactics before routine setup moves.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge d4 immediately, question the b5-knight, and avoid loose central pawns.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

Black's ...c5 and ...e5 attack the center; White can use Nb5 and dxc5 tactics.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Nb5 often threatens Nc7+, so Black's queen and rook alignment matters.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Playing Nb5 automatically when Black can chase it and gain tempi.

MEMORY CUE

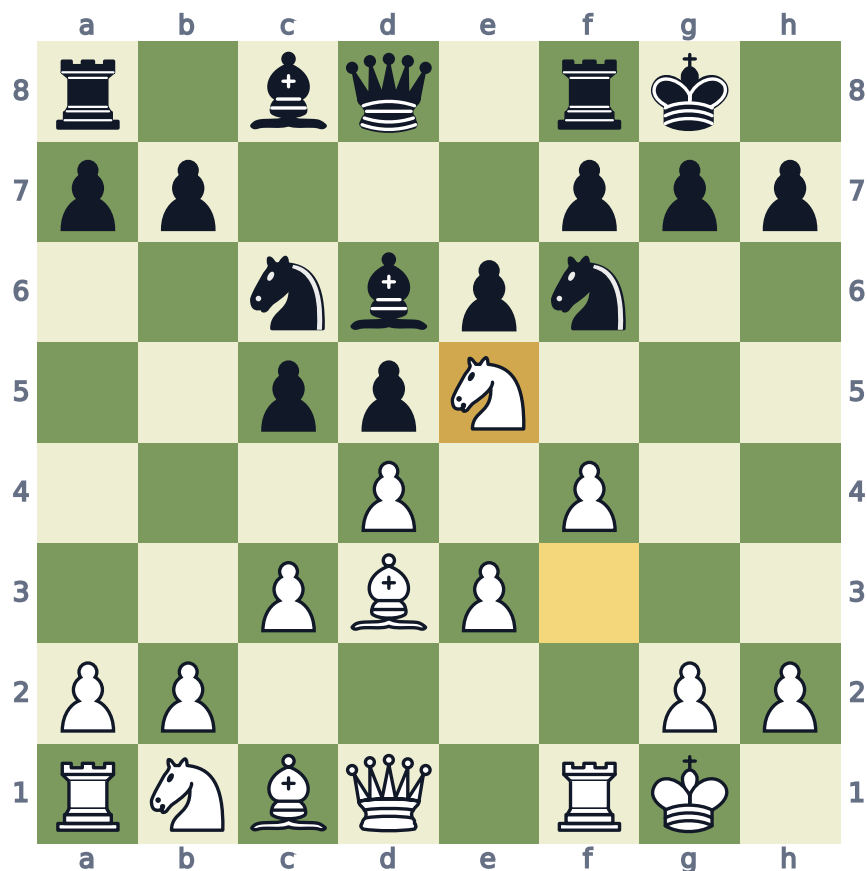
Nc3 turns the London from a shell into a tactical system.

TRANSITION MAP 46 | D00-A45

Stonewall Attack

IDENTITY

White fixes pawns on dark squares and builds a kingside attack around Ne5.



1. d4 d5 2. e3 Nf6 3. Bd3 e6 4. f4 c5 5. c3 Nc6 6. Nf3 Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. Ne5

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 46

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Place a knight on e5, aim pieces at the king, and solve the c1-bishop deliberately.

BLACK'S PLAN

Challenge e5, use the weak e4-square, and open the queenside or center.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's g4-g5 can attack; Black's ...c5 and ...b6 challenge the rigid chain.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Bxh7+ ideas appear when the knight on e5 and queen support the attack.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Ignoring the bad c1-bishop and believing a fixed structure needs no maintenance.

MEMORY CUE

Own e5, attack the king, repair the light bishop.

TRANSITION MAP 47 | A46-A48

Torre Attack

IDENTITY

White develops simply with Bg5 and keeps several central structures available.



1. d4 Nf6 2. Nf3 e6 3. Bg5 d5 4. e3 Be7 5. Bd3 O-O 6. O-O b6 7. Nbd2 Bb7

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 47

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Castle, decide between c4 and a Colle-like e4 setup, and use the pin constructively.

BLACK'S PLAN

Break the pin, challenge d4, and avoid letting White build e4 for free.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e4 or c4 changes the character; Black's ...c5 is standard.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The f6 pin can support e4-e5, but only while the bishop remains safe.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Treating the bishop pin as a permanent threat while neglecting central development.

MEMORY CUE

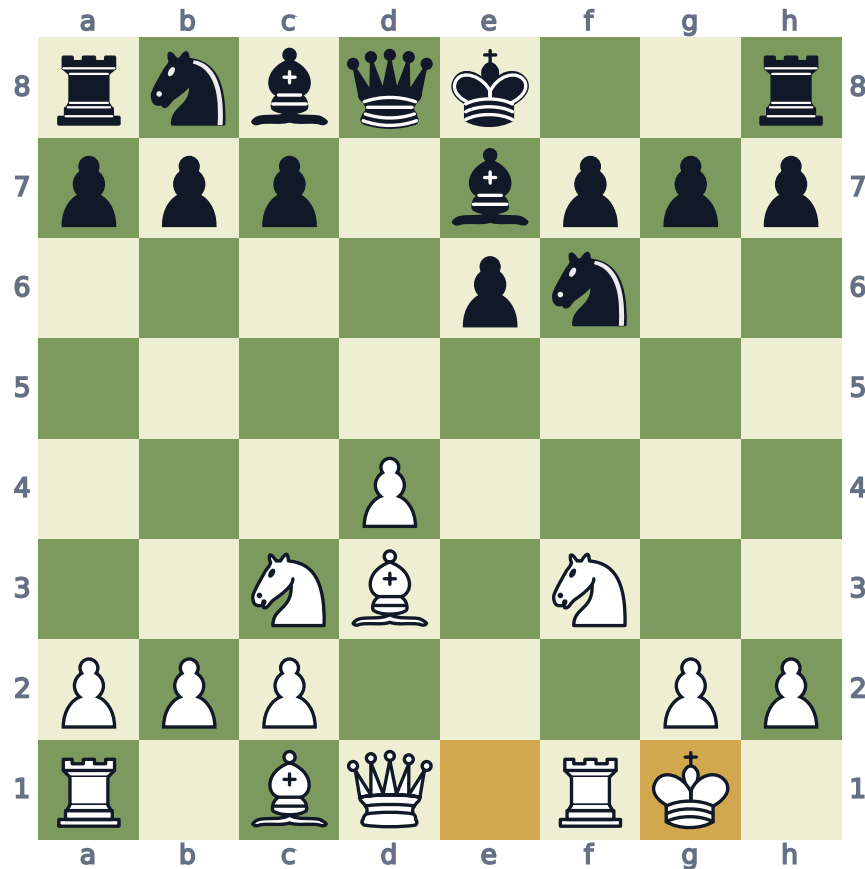
Simple development, then choose the right center.

TRANSITION MAP 48 | D00

Blackmar-Diemer Gambit

IDENTITY

White offers a pawn for fast development and open attacking lines.



1. d4 d5 2. e4 dxe4 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. f3 exf3 5. Nxf3 e6 6. Bd3 Be7 7. O-O

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 48

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Develop every piece, castle, and use open files and diagonals before Black consolidates.

BLACK'S PLAN

Defend accurately, trade attacking pieces, and return the pawn when it completes development.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White may use Ne5 and Qe1-h4; Black seeks ...c5 to attack the center.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

Pressure on f7 and the f-file can create sacrifices when Black's king is unready.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Trying to force a quick mate instead of maintaining development-based compensation.

MEMORY CUE

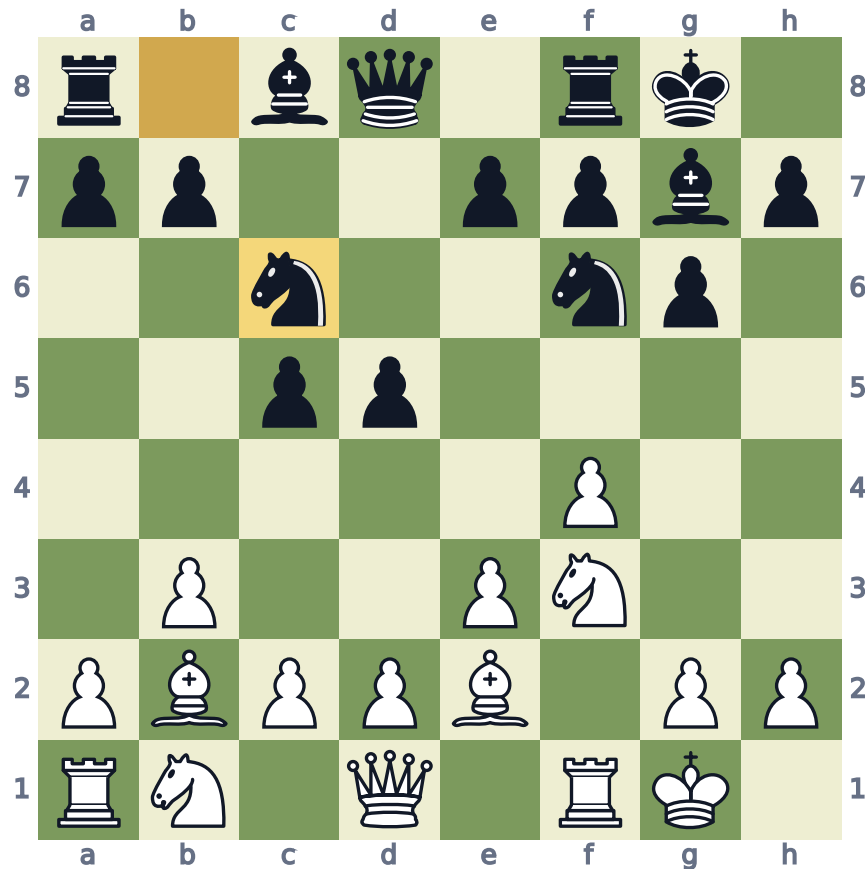
The pawn buys initiative, not a guaranteed attack.

TRANSITION MAP 49 | A02-A03

Bird Opening

IDENTITY

White controls e5 with the f-pawn and often builds a Dutch-style position with colors reversed.



1. f4 d5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. e3 g6 4. b3 Bg7 5. Bb2 O-O 6. Be2 c5 7. O-O Nc6

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 49

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Fianchetto the queen bishop, secure the king, and use e4 or Ne5 when supported.

BLACK'S PLAN

Claim the center, exploit the weakened diagonal, and challenge e5.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e4 is the central goal; Black's ...e5 can challenge immediately.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

The early f-pawn move weakens the king diagonal, making checks on h4 a recurring detail.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Assuming the extra tempo removes every danger created by f4.

MEMORY CUE

Control e5, guard the king diagonal, build e4.

TRANSITION MAP 50 | A05-A08

King's Indian Attack

IDENTITY

White uses a universal kingside fianchetto and prepares e4 without revealing the center early.



1. Nf3 d5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 e6 4. O-O Be7 5. d3 O-O 6. Nbd2 c5 7. e4 Nc6 8. Re1

TRANSITION QUESTION

The opening is ending. Before choosing another memorized move, identify: (1) the structure, (2) the least active piece, (3) the thematic break, (4) the opponent's counterplay, and (5) the exchange that would favor you.

TRANSITION MAP 50

Plans, break, motif, and warning

WHITE'S PLAN

Establish e4, use e5 when it gains space, and build a kingside attack with coordinated pieces.

BLACK'S PLAN

Use central space, open the queenside, and challenge e4 before White's attack becomes automatic.

THEMATIC PAWN BREAK

White's e5 and later h4-h5 can attack; Black's ...d4 or ...b5 creates counterplay.

TYPICAL TACTICAL MOTIF

A closed center can enable a knight transfer to f1-h2-g4 and an attack on the king.

COMMON LEARNING MISTAKE

Following the setup mechanically when Black's center demands an immediate response.

MEMORY CUE

Build the shell, close with e5 when useful, then maneuver.

RETRIEVAL TEST

Can you explain the course without looking?

1

State the five-step decision protocol from memory.

2

Name three recognition cues that should make you slow down.

3

Choose five learning units and explain the causal mechanism behind each rule.

4

For each chosen rule, give one position where it should not be applied mechanically.

5

Describe the opponent's strongest practical resource in your most recent serious game.

6

Name one recurring error and the exact training drill that addresses its cause.

SCORING

2 points: accurate rule plus mechanism. 1 point: useful but incomplete. 0 points: slogan only. Restudy any item below 2 and retrieve it again tomorrow.

TRAINING PLAN

Four weeks to make the ideas usable

WEEK 1 - UNDERSTAND

Study the first quarter of the course. After every lesson, explain why the rule works and when it fails.

WEEK 2 - RECOGNIZE

Study the second quarter. Mix old and new diagrams so the name of the motif is not given in advance.

WEEK 3 - CALCULATE

Finish the course. Use a clock and write candidates, best defense, and endpoint evaluation.

WEEK 4 - TRANSFER

Play two slow games. Mark every moment when the course's protocol changed your decision, then analyze unaided.

LONG-TERM REVIEW

Return after 7, 14, and 30 days. Do not reread first. Attempt the retrieval test, review only missed items, and find one example from your own games.

REFERENCE

How this course fits the library

COURSE ROLE

Move beyond memorization by connecting every opening to its pawn breaks, piece placements, tactical motifs, common mistakes, and first middlegame decision.

LIBRARY PRINCIPLE

Strong chess comes from a loop: notice the right features, generate serious candidates, calculate the opponent's best resistance, evaluate the destination position, and learn from the decision process.

ABOUT THE DIAGRAMS

Boards use Cburnett-style vector chess pieces with solid dark pieces and high-contrast olive and cream squares. Piece artwork is credited to Colin M. L. Burnett and the Lichess Cburnett set under GPLv2+.

EDITION NOTES

First edition, September 2026. 50 learning units. Explanations and exercises are designed for personal study and should be tested against actual games and concrete calculation.

THE FINAL QUESTION

What will you do differently on your very next move? If the course has not changed a behavior, choose one rule, attach it to a visible board cue, and practice it in five slow games.